SFINCO GUIDES · SERIES 1

iPhone Protection

Your simple guide to staying safe online

Leon Tavares

SFINCO.COM.AU

iPhone Protection
Sfinco Guides, Volume 1 of 8

First published 2025 by Sfinco.

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Contents

Introduction 4

Why your iPhone is a target 9

Locking the front door 17

Your Apple ID and iCloud 28

App permissions 43

Scams, fake texts and phishing 59

Wi-Fi and VPN 78

Find My and what to do if stolen 91

Your 15-minute security checkup 101

Glossary 107

- Quick reference card 110
- Monthly security checkup 112
- More books in the series 114
- Scan to continue your Sfinco journey 116
- About the author 117

Introduction

Let's be honest, nobody wakes up in the morning thinking: "I should probably review my iPhone's privacy settings today."

Life is busy. Technology is confusing. And the people who design scams are unfortunately very good at what they do.

That is why this guide exists.

This is not a technical manual. There are no complicated diagrams, no long lists of jargon, and no assumption that you already know what a "VPN" is or why "two-factor authentication" sounds like something from a spy film. (It isn't, and by the end of this book, you will wonder how you ever went without it.)

What this guide is, is a plain-English, step-by-step walkthrough of the most important things you can do right now to protect yourself on your iPhone. Each chapter tackles one area of your digital life, explains why it matters in everyday terms, and then shows you, with clear illustrations, exactly what to do and where to find it.

Whether you are someone who has had an iPhone for years and never thought much about security, or someone who recently heard a story about a friend getting scammed and wants to make sure it never happens to you, this book is written for you.

Who is this book for?

This guide is for anyone who uses an iPhone and wants to feel confident that their personal information, their money, and their family are protected. You do not need to be "tech-savvy." You just need to be willing to spend a few hours going through these steps, most of which take less than two minutes each.

- In particular, this guide will be helpful if you:
- have ever received a suspicious phone call, text message, or email and wondered whether it was real
- are not entirely sure what your Apple ID is or why it matters so much
- share an iPhone plan with family members and want to keep everyone safe
- have a parent, grandparent, or older relative who uses an iPhone and worries about online scams
- simply want peace of mind, knowing your phone is locked down and your information is protected

A quick word from the author

I work in banking and technology on the Sunshine Coast in Queensland, and I spend a lot of time helping people, particularly older Australians, navigate the digital world safely. What I have seen over and over again is not stupidity or carelessness. It is a gap.

The people who design scams and cyberattacks are professionals. They are well-funded, creative, and relentless. Meanwhile, most of us were never taught the basics of digital self-defence. We were handed a smartphone and told to get on with it.

This guide is my attempt to close that gap, one iPhone at a time.

The steps in this book are the same ones I walk through with my own family members. They are practical, they are proven, and they do not require any special skills. All you need is your iPhone, a bit of time, and this book.

Let's get started.

How to use this book

This book is designed to be used, not just read. Here is how to get the most out of it.

Work through it chapter by chapter

Each chapter builds gently on the one before it, starting with the most fundamental protections (your passcode and Face ID) and working through to more advanced topics (Wi-Fi safety and what to do if your phone is ever lost or stolen). If you are new to iPhone security, the best approach is to start at Chapter 1 and work your way through.

That said, every chapter also stands on its own. If there is a specific topic that is urgent for you right now, scam texts, for example, or backing up your phone, feel free to jump straight there.

Do the steps as you go

This is not a book to read in bed and then forget about. It is a book to read with your iPhone in your hand. Each chapter includes step-by-step instructions with screenshots showing exactly what you will see on your screen. Work through each step as you read it, and by the time you finish a chapter, that protection is already in place.

> **TIP**
> If you find a step confusing or your screen looks different from the screenshots, don't panic. iOS updates occasionally change where settings live. A quick search online for the setting name will usually point you in the right direction, or ask someone you trust for help.

Use the checklist at the back

The final chapter of this book contains a one-page security checklist you can use every month to make sure your iPhone stays protected over time. Tear it out. Stick it on the fridge. Set a reminder on your calendar for the first Sunday of every month. Five minutes a month is all it takes to stay on top of things.

Share it with someone you care about

If you know someone, a parent, a neighbour, a friend, who could benefit from this guide, please share it with them. Scammers target people who are isolated and uninformed. The more people in your circle who know these basics, the safer everyone is.

A note on screenshots and iOS versions

The screenshots in this book were taken using iOS 17. If you are using a slightly older or newer version of iOS, some screens may look a little different, but the core settings and steps are almost always in the same place.

To check which version of iOS you are running: go to Settings > General > About, and look for "Software Version." If your version is significantly older than iOS 16, consider updating before working through this guide, as some features may not be available on older software.

> **IMPORTANT**
> Keeping your iPhone updated is one of the single most important things you can do for your security. Apple regularly releases updates that fix known vulnerabilities. We cover this in detail in Chapter 8.

What this book does not cover

This guide focuses specifically on your iPhone. It does not cover Mac computers, Android phones, or general internet safety beyond what relates directly to your device. If you are interested in those topics, they are covered in other volumes in the Sfinco Guides series.

This guide also does not go deep into corporate or business-level security. If you run a small business and want to protect your team and your systems, take a look at the Sfinco Guide for Small Business, coming soon in Series 2.

Ready? Turn the page. Chapter 1 starts with a story you might recognise.

- sfinco.com.au
- Part of the Sfinco Guides series, protecting Australians online

01

Why your iPhone is a target

What scammers are after, and how they get in

> **SOUNDS FAMILIAR?**
>
> Diane, 71, from the Sunshine Coast, received a text message from what appeared to be her bank. It said her account had been flagged for suspicious activity and she needed to verify her details immediately. The link looked right. The logo looked right. She clicked it, entered her name, date of birth, and internet banking password. Within four hours, $14,000 had been transferred out of her account. Diane is not careless. She is intelligent, experienced, and careful with her money. She was targeted by professionals, and she had no idea what to look for.
>
> This is a composite example, built from patterns commonly reported to Scamwatch and IDCARE, not a specific real person. If it sounds familiar, that's exactly the point.

Stories like Diane's are not rare. They happen every day across Australia, to people of all ages, all backgrounds, and all levels of technical experience. The Australian Competition and Consumer Commission reported over $3.1 billion lost to scams in Australia in 2022 alone, the worst year on record. Losses have fallen since that peak, but have stayed above $2 billion every year that's followed.

And the iPhone, one of the most popular and trusted devices in the world, sits right at the centre of it all.

This chapter is not here to frighten you. It is here to show you clearly what is actually happening, why your phone is valuable to the people who want to misuse it, and what the most common

methods of attack look like. Because once you know what to look for, most of these threats become remarkably easy to avoid.

What is actually on your iPhone?

To understand why your iPhone is worth targeting, it helps to think about what is stored on it. Probably far more than you realise.

- Your bank accounts, through banking apps or saved browser sessions
- Your email, which can be used to reset passwords for almost everything else
- Your Apple ID, the master key to your Apple account, iCloud, purchases, and Find My
- Your photos, including images of documents, Medicare cards, passports, and bank statements that many people photograph for convenience
- Your contacts, names, phone numbers, and addresses of everyone you know
- Your location history, everywhere you have been, often going back months or years
- Your saved passwords, stored in Safari or third-party apps
- Your text messages, including one-time codes sent by your bank for verification
- Your health data, through Apple Health and connected apps

> **DID YOU KNOW?**
> A scammer who gains access to your iPhone, or even just your email account, can often reset your internet banking password, intercept the verification code sent to your phone, and drain your account, all within a few minutes. Your phone and your email together are sometimes called the 'keys to the kingdom.' That is not an exaggeration.

Most people think of their iPhone as a phone and a camera. Scammers think of it as a vault.

How do attacks actually happen?

There is a common misconception that getting scammed or hacked requires the victim to do something obviously stupid, click a link that says "FREE MONEY" in flashing letters, or hand their phone to a stranger. The reality is very different.

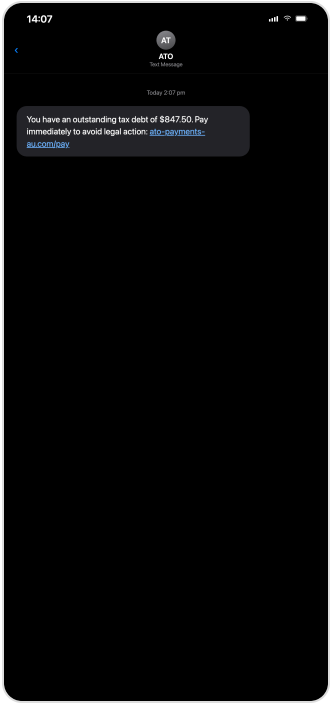
Modern attacks are designed to be convincing. They are tested on thousands of people before they reach you. They exploit genuine moments of uncertainty, urgency, or helpfulness. Here are the most common methods used against iPhone users in Australia today.

Phishing, fake messages that look real

Phishing is the practice of sending a message, by text, email, or even voicemail, that impersonates a trusted organisation. The goal is to get you to click a link and enter your details on a fake website that looks identical to the real one.

- In Australia, the most commonly impersonated organisations are:
- The Australian Taxation Office (ATO): "You have an outstanding tax debt"

- myGov: "Your account has been suspended"
- Australia Post: "Your parcel could not be delivered"
- Telstra or Optus: "Your account has been compromised"
- Your bank: "Unusual activity detected on your account"
- Apple: "Your Apple ID has been locked"



A real example of an ATO impersonation scam SMS. Note the generic greeting, urgent language, and the link that does not match the official ato.gov.au domain.

WARNING

A genuine message from the ATO, your bank, or Apple will NEVER ask you to click a link and enter your password, PIN, or full account details. If a message asks for this, it is a scam. When in doubt, close the message, go directly to the official website by typing it yourself, or call the organisation on a number you find independently, not one in the message.

Vishing, scam phone calls

Vishing (voice phishing) involves a phone call, often from someone claiming to be from your bank, the police, the ATO, or even Apple support. The caller will usually tell you that something is urgently wrong, your account has been hacked, you owe a tax debt, your computer has a virus, or your identity has been stolen.

They will sound professional and confident. They may already know your name, your address, or even part of your account number (this information is sometimes purchased from data breaches). And they will use urgency and fear to push you into acting quickly, before you have time to think clearly.

SOUNDS FAMILIAR?

A 68-year-old man in Brisbane received a call from someone claiming to be from the fraud team at Coastal Trust Bank. The caller knew his name, suburb, and the last four digits of his card. He was told his account had been compromised and he needed to transfer his savings to a 'safe account' immediately. He transferred $47,000 before a family member intervened. The bank cannot verify caller identity over the phone. Scammers exploit this completely.

This is a composite example, built from patterns commonly reported to Scamwatch and IDCARE, not a specific real bank or person. If it sounds familiar, that's exactly the point.

Fake app updates and malicious apps

Occasionally, scammers create apps that look like legitimate tools, a utility, a game, a productivity app, but are designed to harvest your data or display fake alerts. Apple's App Store has strong protections against this, but it is not perfect.

More commonly, you might receive an email or pop-up message claiming that your iPhone needs a security update and directing you to download something. Apple never delivers updates this way. All genuine iPhone updates come through Settings > General > Software Update and nowhere else.

SIM swapping

SIM swapping is a more sophisticated attack in which a criminal contacts your mobile carrier, Telstra, Optus, or Vodafone, and convinces them to transfer your phone number to a new SIM card that the criminal controls.

Once they have your number, they can receive the SMS verification codes that your bank sends when you log in or make transfers. Combined with a stolen password, this gives them full access to your accounts.

We cover how to protect yourself against SIM swapping in Chapter 3.

Why older Australians are targeted more

It is worth addressing this directly, because pretending otherwise would not help anyone.

- People over 60 are disproportionately targeted by phone and online scams. This is not because older people are less

intelligent or less capable. It is because of several factors that scammers deliberately exploit:

- Higher average savings and superannuation balances make the potential reward greater
- Less familiarity with how digital systems actually work makes deception easier
- Greater tendency to be polite and engage with callers rather than hanging up
- More time at home and more likely to answer calls and messages
- Less likely to have discussed scam tactics with others or seen warnings on social media

> **DID YOU KNOW?**
> According to the ACCC's Scamwatch, Australians aged 65 and over lost more money to scams per capita than any other age group in 2022. Investment scams and remote access scams were the most costly. But the same data also shows that when older Australians are informed and aware, they report scam attempts at higher rates than younger Australians. Awareness is genuinely protective.

This guide was written with this in mind. Every step in the chapters that follow is chosen specifically because it addresses the most common and most damaging risks for everyday iPhone users in Australia. You do not need to become a cybersecurity expert. You just need to know enough to recognise the warning signs, and to have the right settings in place so that even if something does go wrong, the damage is limited.

The good news

Here is what the scammers do not want you to know: most of these attacks have simple, effective defences.

A strong passcode. Two-factor authentication on your Apple ID. Knowing what a phishing message looks like. Having a backup of your phone. That is honestly most of it.

None of these things are complicated. None of them cost money. And none of them require you to become a technology expert. They just require a bit of time and the willingness to follow a few steps.

That is exactly what this book is for. Each chapter that follows will take one area of your iPhone's security, explain why it matters, and walk you through exactly what to do, step by step, with screenshots.

By the time you finish this book, your iPhone will be significantly more protected than it is right now. And more importantly, you will understand why, which means you will be able to make better decisions every time something suspicious comes your way.

What's next: In Chapter 2, we start with the most fundamental layer of iPhone security, your passcode and Face ID. It takes about ten minutes to set up properly, and it is the single most important thing protecting your phone if it is ever lost or stolen.

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02

Locking the front door

Passcode, Face ID, and what to do before your phone leaves your hands

Think of your iPhone as a house. Your contacts, your bank apps, your photos, your emails, they are all inside, and they are all valuable. The front door to that house is your passcode and Face ID. If someone can get past that door, they have access to everything.

This chapter covers the three layers of your iPhone's front-door security, and one feature that most people have never heard of, which can make an enormous difference if your phone is ever stolen.

None of this takes more than ten minutes to set up. Let's go through it step by step.

Layer 1, Your passcode

Every iPhone has a passcode, a number or combination you enter to unlock your phone. But not all passcodes are equally strong, and the default settings are not always the safest.

What most people use, and why it's not enough

The most common iPhone passcodes in Australia are: 123456, 000000, 111111, your birth year, and your birth date. Scammers and thieves know this. When someone steals a phone and wants to get in, these are the first things they try.

A four-digit PIN gives 10,000 possible combinations. A six-digit PIN gives 1,000,000. A custom alphanumeric code, using letters, numbers, and symbols, gives billions. The difference matters.

> **DID YOU KNOW?**
> Research by the security firm ESET found that approximately one in five people use one of the top 10 most predictable passcodes. If you are using your birth year, your house number, or a repeating digit, you are not as protected as you think.

- How to change your passcode right now
- Settings path: Settings > Face ID & Passcode > Change Passcode

Open Settings on your iPhone home screen, it looks like a grey box with gears.

Scroll down and tap Face ID & Passcode.

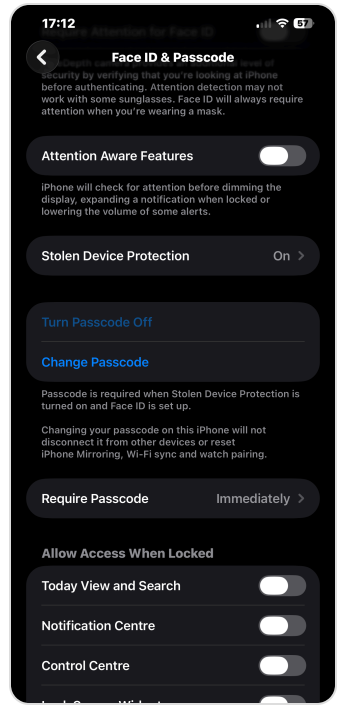
You will be prompted to enter your current passcode.

Tap Change Passcode. Enter your current passcode again when prompted.

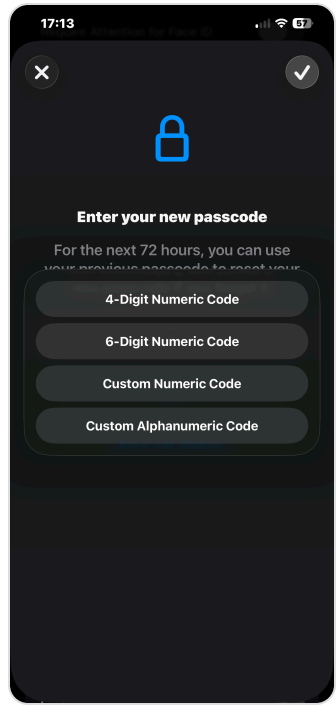
Tap Passcode Options at the top of the screen. You will see four choices.

Select Custom Alphanumeric Code for the strongest option, or Custom Numeric Code for a longer number if you prefer.

Enter your new passcode twice to confirm it.



The Face ID & Passcode screen in Settings. Tap 'Change Passcode' and then 'Passcode Options' to choose a stronger format.



Tap 'Passcode Options' to reveal the full list. 'Custom Alphanumeric Code' is the strongest choice, it allows letters, numbers, and symbols.

TIP

Choose a passphrase rather than a random string of characters. Something like 'Noosa2019beach!' is far easier to remember than 'xK#92mP!' and just as strong. A phrase that means something to you but nothing to anyone else is ideal.

WARNING

Do not use: your date of birth, your address, your phone number, your child's name, your pet's name, or any number or word that someone who knows you could guess. Also avoid: 123456, 000000, 111111, and your birth year, these are the first things a thief will try.

Layer 2, Face ID

Face ID uses the camera on the front of your iPhone to recognise your face and unlock the phone, without you needing to type your passcode every time. It is fast, convenient, and surprisingly secure.

Apple's Face ID system maps over 30,000 invisible dots across your face to create a mathematical model unique to you. It cannot be fooled by a photograph. It updates itself gradually over time to account for changes in your appearance, glasses, a beard, ageing.

If Face ID is not yet set up on your phone, or if it has been behaving unreliably, here is how to set it up properly.

- Setting up Face ID
- Settings path: Settings > Face ID & Passcode > Set Up Face ID

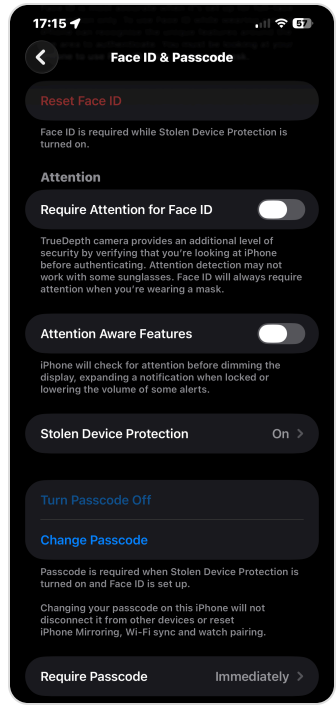
Open Settings and tap Face ID & Passcode.

Tap Set Up Face ID.

Hold your iPhone in portrait orientation at eye level, about 25–30 cm from your face, roughly arm's length.

Follow the on-screen instructions: move your head slowly in a circle so the camera can capture your face from different angles. You will do this twice.

Tap Done when complete. Face ID is now active.



The Face ID setup screen. Follow the circle with your head to let the camera map your face from all angles. The process takes about 30 seconds.

> **TIP**
>
> If you wear glasses, set up Face ID both with and without them. Go to Settings > Face ID & Passcode > Set Up an Alternate Appearance to add a second scan. This also works for significant changes in appearance such as a new beard or different hairstyle.

- What Face ID is used for
- Once set up, Face ID can be used to:
- Unlock your iPhone
- Authorise Apple Pay purchases
- Confirm App Store and iTunes purchases
- AutoFill saved passwords in Safari

- Unlock third-party apps that support Face ID, including most banking apps

> **WELL DONE IF YOU HAVE THIS**
> If your banking app uses Face ID to log in, that is a good sign, it means someone who picks up your phone cannot open your banking app even if they somehow know your iPhone passcode, because your face is the second lock.

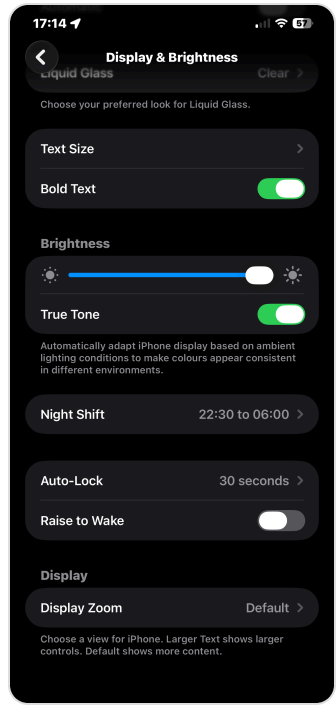
Layer 3, Auto-lock

Auto-lock controls how quickly your iPhone locks itself after you stop using it. When your phone locks, the screen turns off and Face ID or your passcode is required to get back in.

Many people set this to a long time, or even Never, because it feels convenient. But a phone that stays unlocked is a phone that anyone can pick up and use.

Settings›Display & Brightness›Auto-Lock

The recommended setting is 30 seconds or 1 minute. This might feel short at first, but you will quickly get used to it, and it means your phone locks itself almost immediately if you put it down, drop it, or have it taken from you.



The Auto-Lock setting under Display & Brightness. 30 seconds is the recommended setting, it locks the phone quickly without being disruptive during normal use.

> **WARNING**
>
> If your Auto-Lock is set to 'Never', your phone will stay fully accessible for as long as the screen is on, even if you leave it on a table in a café. Change this to 30 seconds or 1 minute today.

The feature most people have never heard of, Stolen Device Protection

In 2024, Apple introduced a feature called Stolen Device Protection. It was created in response to a specific and alarming pattern of theft: thieves watching people type their passcodes in public, at

cafés, on public transport, in shopping centres, then stealing the phone and using the passcode to completely take over the victim's Apple account.

- With the old system, someone who knew your passcode could:
- Change your Apple ID password
- Turn off Find My iPhone, making the phone untraceable
- Remove Face ID and add their own
- Add a new recovery key, locking you out of your own account permanently
- Access and drain your banking apps

Stolen Device Protection changes this. When it is turned on and your phone is away from your trusted locations (home and work), certain sensitive actions require Face ID, and cannot be overridden by your passcode. This means that even if a thief knows your passcode, they cannot take over your Apple account without your face.

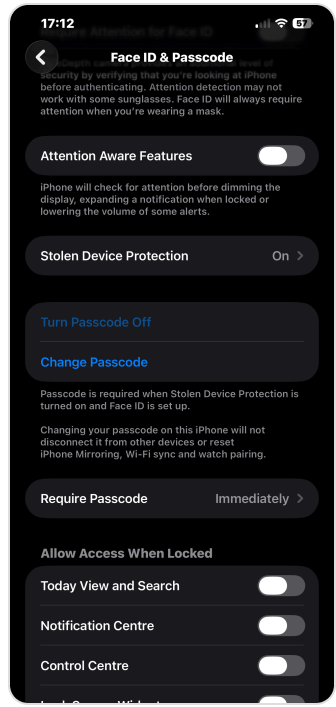
- How to turn on Stolen Device Protection
- Settings path: Settings > Face ID & Passcode > Stolen Device Protection

Open Settings and tap Face ID & Passcode.

Enter your passcode when prompted.

Scroll down to Stolen Device Protection and tap Turn On Protection.

Confirm by authenticating with Face ID.



The Stolen Device Protection toggle in Settings. This is one of the most important security features Apple has ever introduced, turn it on now if you haven't already.

> **DID YOU KNOW?**
>
> Stolen Device Protection is available on iPhones running iOS 17.3 or later. To check your iOS version: Settings > General > About > Software Version. If your software is older than iOS 17.3, update it first (Settings > General > Software Update) and then enable this feature.

> **TIP**
> Make sure your home address and work address are saved in your iPhone's Significant Locations so Stolen Device Protection recognises them as trusted places. Settings > Privacy & Security > Location Services > System Services > Significant Locations. This prevents the feature from triggering inconveniently at familiar locations.

Quick review, your chapter 2 checklist

Before moving on, take two minutes to confirm you have done all four of the following. Tick each one off as you go.

- I have changed my passcode to a Custom Alphanumeric Code or a long custom number
- Face ID is set up and working correctly on my iPhone
- Auto-lock is set to 30 seconds or 1 minute
- Stolen Device Protection is turned ON

> **WELL DONE IF YOU HAVE THIS**
> If all four are done, well done. Your iPhone's front door is now locked properly. These four steps alone put you ahead of the vast majority of iPhone users in Australia. Everything else in this book adds further layers on top of this foundation.

What's next: In Chapter 3, we cover your Apple ID, the most important account on your phone. If someone gains access to your Apple ID, they can control your device remotely, wipe your photos, and lock you out of everything. We show you exactly how to lock it down.

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03

Your Apple ID and iCloud

Protecting the master key to your digital life

If your iPhone is a house, then your Apple ID is the master key. Not just to the front door, to every room, every cupboard, and every safe inside. It controls your iCloud account, your photos, your backups, your App Store purchases, your iMessage history, your contacts, and Find My iPhone.

It is also the account that scammers most want to get their hands on, because if they have your Apple ID, they effectively have your phone.

This chapter covers how to check whether your Apple ID is properly secured, how to set up two-factor authentication if you haven't already, and what to do in the scenarios that frighten people most, being locked out, or suspecting someone else has access.

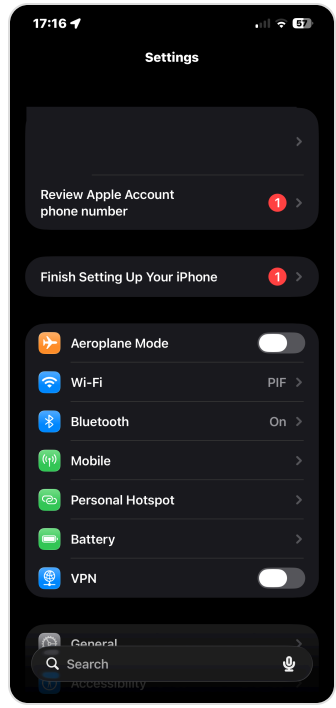
> **SOUNDS FAMILIAR?**
>
> David, 74, from Caloundra, started getting emails claiming to be from Apple saying his account had been used to make purchases he didn't recognise, apps, in-app purchases, subscriptions. He called the number in one of the emails. It wasn't Apple. It was a scammer who had already accessed his account and was now talking him into giving up his verification code. He lost access to his Apple ID for eleven days. Recovering it required a lengthy identity verification process with Apple Support. Two-factor authentication would have stopped this entirely, and it takes four minutes to set up.
>
> This is a composite example, built from patterns commonly reported to Scamwatch and IDCARE, not a specific real person. If it sounds familiar, that's exactly the point.

What is your Apple ID, exactly?

Your Apple ID is the email address and password you use to sign in to Apple services. It is usually the email address you used when you first set up your iPhone, often a Gmail, Hotmail, or iCloud address.

To see what Apple ID is currently signed in on your phone, look at the very top of Settings. You will see your name and, underneath it, your Apple ID email address.

Settings›[Your Name at the top]



Your Apple ID is shown at the very top of Settings, just below your name. Tap it to see everything connected to your account.

Tapping your name opens your Apple ID page, where you can see every device signed in to your account, your iCloud storage, and your payment methods. We will come back to this page several

times in this chapter.

The password, and why it matters more than any other

Your Apple ID password is the most important password on your phone. If it is weak, reused from another account, or written on a sticky note on your fridge, everything else in this book is undermined.

What makes a strong Apple ID password?

- At least 12 characters long
- A mix of uppercase and lowercase letters, numbers, and at least one symbol
- Not a word from the dictionary, even with letter substitutions like '3' for 'e'
- Not your name, your pet's name, your birth year, or your address
- Not used for any other account, especially not your email or banking

> **TIP**
> The strongest passwords are passphrases, three or four random words joined together, with a number and symbol added. For example: 'Mango!Rainfall47Desk' is extremely strong, completely unique, and far easier to remember than a random string of characters. Pick words that have no connection to each other or to you personally.

- How to change your Apple ID password
- Settings path: Settings > [Your Name] > Sign-In & Security > Change Password

Open Settings and tap your name at the top.

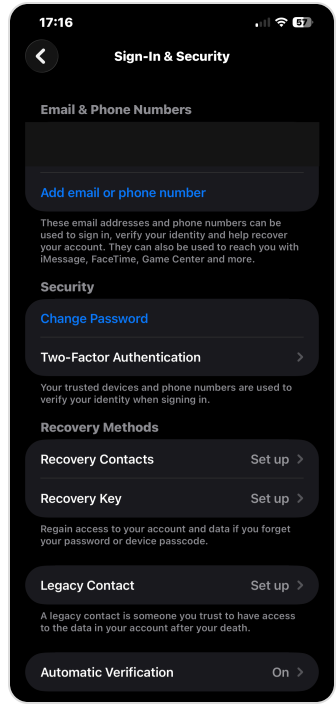
Tap Sign-In & Security.

Tap Change Password.

You may be asked to enter your iPhone passcode first.

Enter your current Apple ID password, then type and confirm your new one.

Tap Change to save.



The Sign-In & Security screen under your Apple ID settings. This is also where you manage two-factor authentication and trusted phone numbers.

> **WARNING**
> After changing your Apple ID password, you will be signed out of iCloud on all other devices. This is normal. You will need to sign back in on your iPad, Mac, or other Apple devices using your new password. Have those devices nearby before you make the change.

Two-factor authentication, your single most important security step

Two-factor authentication, often written as 2FA, means that signing in to your Apple ID requires two things: your password, and a six-digit code sent to a trusted device or phone number that only you have access to.

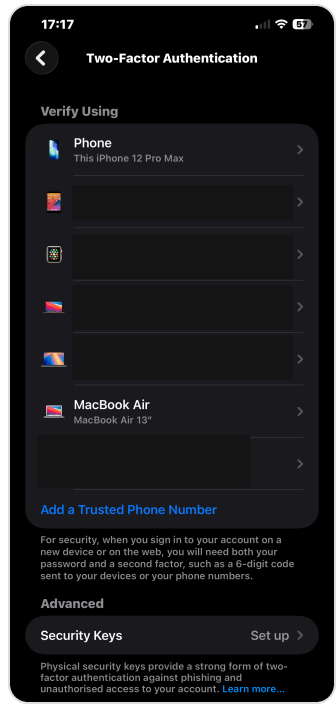
Even if a scammer somehow obtains your Apple ID password, they cannot access your account without that code. And since the code arrives on your iPhone or is sent to your phone number, they would need to physically have your device to intercept it.

This one feature stops the vast majority of account takeover attacks. It is not optional, it is essential.

> **DID YOU KNOW?**
> Apple now requires two-factor authentication for most Apple ID accounts created after 2019. However, many older accounts still do not have it enabled, particularly those created when iPhones first became popular. If your account is more than five years old, there is a good chance 2FA is not yet active. Check right now using the steps below.

- How to check if two-factor authentication is already on
- Settings path: Settings > [Your Name] > Sign-In & Security

Look for the line that says Two-Factor Authentication. If it says On next to it, you are already protected. If it says Off, or if you do not see this option at all, follow the steps below to turn it on.



The Sign-In & Security screen. 'Two-Factor Authentication: On' means you are protected. If it shows 'Off', follow the steps in the next section immediately.

How to turn on two-factor authentication

Open Settings and tap your name at the top.

Tap Sign-In & Security.

Tap Turn On Two-Factor Authentication.

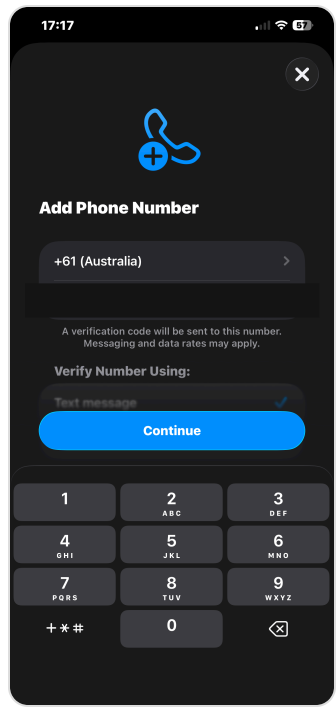
Tap Continue.

Enter a trusted phone number , this is the number where Apple will send verification codes. Use your mobile number.

Choose how to receive codes: Text Message is the simplest option for most people.

Apple will send a six-digit code to that number. Enter it to confirm.

Two-factor authentication is now active.



Enter your mobile number as the trusted phone number. Apple will send a six-digit code here whenever someone tries to sign in to your Apple ID from a new device.

WELL DONE IF YOU HAVE THIS

Two-factor authentication is now on. From this point forward, anyone who tries to sign in to your Apple ID, including you, on a new device, will need both your password and a six-digit code sent to your phone. This closes the single most commonly exploited vulnerability in Apple account security.

Trusted phone numbers and trusted devices

Two-factor authentication works by sending a code to a trusted device or trusted phone number. It is worth understanding what these are and making sure yours are up to date.

Trusted devices

A trusted device is any Apple device, iPhone, iPad, or Mac, that is already signed in to your Apple ID and has two-factor authentication turned on. When you sign in to a new device or browser, a notification appears on your trusted devices showing the sign-in location and a six-digit code.

Trusted phone numbers

A trusted phone number is a mobile number that can receive SMS codes. You should have at least one, and ideally two, your own mobile number, and perhaps a family member's number as a backup in case your phone is lost or unavailable.

Settings›[Your Name]›Sign-In & Security›Trusted Phone Number

Tap Add a Trusted Phone Number to add a second number.

Enter the number and choose verification method (Text Message recommended).

Enter the code sent to that number to confirm.

> **TIP**
> Adding a trusted family member's number as a backup is a smart move, particularly if you have an adult child or trusted person who could help you recover your account if your phone was ever lost or stolen. Make sure they know why their number is listed and that they should always tell you if they receive an Apple verification code, they should never share it with anyone else, including people claiming to be from Apple.

iCloud, what it is and why it matters

iCloud is Apple's cloud storage service, a secure online space where your iPhone automatically saves copies of your photos, contacts, messages, notes, and app data. It is what allows you to switch to a new iPhone and have everything just appear on the new device as if nothing changed.

iCloud is tied entirely to your Apple ID. Which means that protecting your Apple ID is also protecting your iCloud, they are the same thing.

What is backed up to iCloud?

- By default, iCloud backs up:
- Your photos and videos
- Your contacts, calendars, and reminders
- Your text messages and iMessage history
- Your app data and settings
- Your Safari bookmarks and history
- Your health data
- Your iPhone settings and home screen layout

This means that if your phone is lost, stolen, or damaged, you can restore everything to a new phone from iCloud. It is one of the most valuable features of the iPhone ecosystem, but only if it is turned on and working correctly.

- How to check your iCloud backup is working
- Settings path: Settings > [Your Name] > iCloud > iCloud Backup

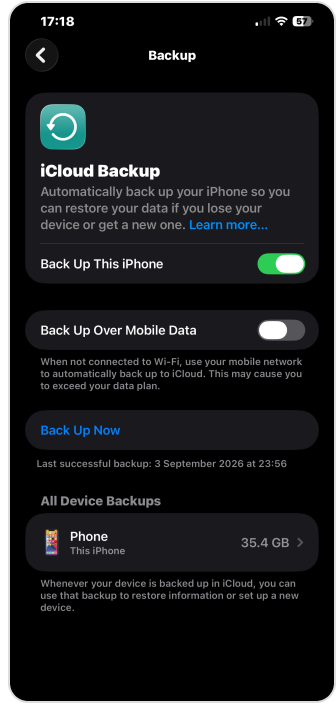
Open Settings and tap your name.

Tap iCloud.

Scroll down and tap iCloud Backup.

Make sure iCloud Backup is toggled ON (green).

Check the line that says Last Successful Backup. If this was more than a week ago, tap Back Up Now to run a manual backup.



The iCloud Backup screen. The toggle should be green (on), and the 'Last Successful Backup' date should be recent, ideally within the last 24 hours if you charge your phone overnight.

> **DID YOU KNOW?**
> iCloud backup runs automatically when your iPhone is plugged in to power, connected to Wi-Fi, and the screen is locked, typically overnight while you sleep. If you charge your phone beside your bed, your backup is almost certainly running every night without you needing to do anything.

Reviewing devices signed in to your Apple ID

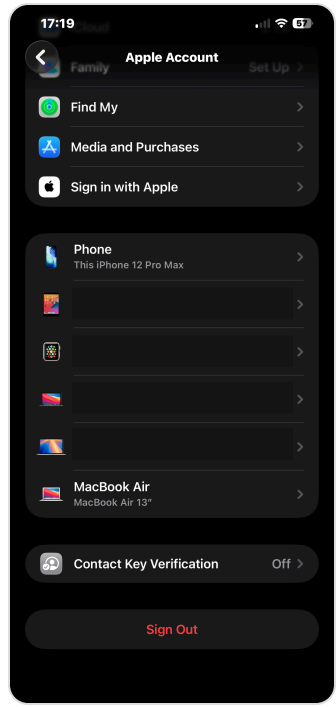
This is something most people have never done, and it only takes a minute. You can see every device currently signed in to your Apple ID, and remove any that should not be there.

This is important because if a family member once borrowed your Apple ID to download an app years ago, or if you have an old device that was never properly signed out, those devices still have access to your account.

Settings›[Your Name]›scroll down to see device list

Scroll to the bottom of your Apple ID page. You will see a list of every Apple device signed in with your account. Tap any device to see its model, iOS version, and whether it is a trusted device for two-factor authentication.

If you see a device you do not recognise, or an old device you no longer own, tap it and select Remove from Account.



Your list of signed-in devices is at the bottom of your Apple ID page. Tap any device to see its details, or to remove it from your account if it should not be there.

> **WARNING**
>
> If you see a device on this list that you do not recognise and do not own, remove it immediately, then change your Apple ID password and contact Apple Support at support.apple.com. An unrecognised device is a strong signal that someone else may have access to your account.

What to do if you are locked out of your Apple ID

Being locked out of your Apple ID is one of the most stressful digital experiences there is. It can happen for several reasons, too many incorrect password attempts, a forgotten password, or losing access

to your trusted phone number.

Here is what to do, in order.

Option 1, Reset your password using a trusted device

If you have another Apple device signed in to your account, an iPad or Mac, you can reset your Apple ID password directly from that device without needing to contact Apple.

On another Apple device: Settings›[Your Name]›Sign-In & Security›Change Password

Option 2, Use account recovery at iforgot.apple.com

Go to iforgot.apple.com on any web browser. Enter your Apple ID email address and follow the prompts. Apple will send a verification code to your trusted phone number or trusted device.

Option 3, Account Recovery Contact

Apple allows you to nominate an Account Recovery Contact, a trusted person who can help you regain access to your account if you are locked out. This person does not get access to your account; they simply receive a code that you use during the recovery process.

Settings›[Your Name]›Sign-In & Security›Account Recovery

> **TIP**
> Setting up an Account Recovery Contact now, before you ever need it, takes about two minutes and could save you days of frustration if you are ever locked out. Choose a trusted adult family member with their own Apple device. They will receive a request to accept the role and can decline if they prefer, their number is not added without their confirmation.

CRITICAL, READ THIS CAREFULLY

Never share your Apple ID verification code with anyone, not even someone claiming to be from Apple Support. Apple will never call you and ask for a verification code. If someone calls you and says they are from Apple and need your code to help you, hang up immediately. This is one of the most common and effective scams targeting iPhone users in Australia. Your code is yours alone, sharing it hands over your account.

Quick review, your chapter 3 checklist

Work through these steps now, with your iPhone in hand. Tick each one as you complete it.

- I know what email address my Apple ID uses (top of Settings)
- My Apple ID password is strong and not used for any other account
- Two-factor authentication is turned ON on my account
- I have at least one trusted phone number added (my own mobile)
- I have checked my iCloud backup and it ran successfully in the last week
- I have reviewed the devices signed in to my account and removed any I do not recognise
- I have set up (or noted down) an Account Recovery Contact

WELL DONE IF YOU HAVE THIS

Your Apple ID is now properly secured. Combined with the passcode and Face ID steps from Chapter 2, your iPhone has two strong, independent layers of protection. The next chapter covers what your apps can see, and how to take that control back.

What's next: In Chapter 4, we look at app permissions, the quiet ways apps on your phone can access your location, camera, microphone, and contacts, often without you realising. We show you how to do a full permissions audit in under fifteen minutes and take back control of what your apps can see.

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04

App permissions

What your apps can see, and how to take back control

Every time you install a new app on your iPhone, it may ask for your permission to access certain parts of your phone, your location, your camera, your microphone, your contacts. You have probably tapped Allow without thinking too much about it, because the app was asking right at the moment you were trying to use it and the request seemed reasonable.

But over months and years of installing apps, those permissions accumulate. Many of them are no longer needed. Some were never needed. And a small number of them are being used in ways that would surprise you.

This chapter explains what each permission actually means in plain English, shows you how to do a full audit of what your apps can currently access, and walks you through revoking anything that should not be there. The whole process takes about fifteen minutes and is one of the most worthwhile things you can do for your privacy.

SOUNDS FAMILIAR?

A woman in her late sixties downloaded a free flashlight app from the App Store. She granted it access to her location and contacts because the app requested them at install. She never questioned it, a flashlight seems harmless. Six months later, a family member with a background in IT checked her phone and found the app had been sending her contact list to servers overseas every 48 hours. The app was removed from the App Store shortly after. Her contacts had already been harvested. The permission was granted in a single tap. It took eighteen months to notice.

This is a composite example, built from patterns commonly reported about app permission abuse, not a specific real person. If it sounds familiar, that's exactly the point.

What are app permissions?

When an app asks for permission to access something on your phone, iOS shows you a pop-up message explaining what it wants and why. You have three choices: Allow, Don't Allow, or, for location, Allow Once, Allow While Using App, or Always.

What many people do not realise is that these permissions can be changed at any time, even after you have granted them. You are never permanently locked in to a choice you made at install. Revoking a permission is just as easy as granting one, and the app continues to work for everything it actually needs.

DID YOU KNOW?

iOS is designed so that apps can only access the permissions you explicitly grant. Unlike some other operating systems, an iPhone app cannot secretly access your camera or microphone without your permission, and iOS shows a coloured dot at the top of your screen whenever your camera (green) or microphone (orange) is actively being used. If you see one of these dots when no app should be recording, investigate immediately.



The green dot means an app is currently using your camera. The orange dot means your microphone is active. Swipe down from the top-right corner to see which app is responsible.

The permission reference guide

Before we do the audit, here is a plain-English explanation of every major permission your iPhone can grant, what it actually means, and when it is reasonable to allow it.

Permission	What it actually means	Allow only when...
📍 Location	What it means The app can see where you are, your suburb, street, or exact GPS coordinates, depending on the setting chosen.	Allow when... Maps, navigation, weather, food delivery, rideshare. Deny for games, shopping, news, and social media unless there is a clear reason.
📷 Camera	What it means The app can activate your camera and capture photos or video.	Allow when... Camera apps, video calling (FaceTime, Zoom), QR code scanners, banking apps that photograph documents. Deny for apps that have no obvious reason to use a camera.
🎤 Microphone	What it means The app can listen through your microphone, including when the app is open in the background.	Allow when... Voice and video calling apps, voice memo apps, dictation tools. Deny for shopping, games, and social media apps unless you actively use voice features.
👥 Contacts	What it means The app can read the names, phone numbers, and email addresses of everyone in your contacts list.	Allow when... Calling and messaging apps (Phone, Messages, WhatsApp). Deny for almost everything else, there is rarely a legitimate reason for a game or shopping app to need your contacts.
🖼️ Photos	What it means The app can view your photo library. 'Full Access' means all photos; 'Selected Photos' means	Allow when... Photo editing apps, printing services, apps where you upload images. Always choose 'Selected Photos' rather than 'Full Access' where possible.

Permission	What it actually means	Allow only when...
	only what you choose to share.	
🔵 Bluetooth	What it means The app can use Bluetooth, which also allows it to detect your location indirectly via Bluetooth beacons in shops and public spaces.	Allow when... Wireless headphone apps, fitness trackers, smart home devices. Deny for apps that have no obvious need for wireless connectivity.
👁️ Tracking	What it means The app wants to track your activity across other apps and websites to build an advertising profile about you.	Allow when... Almost never. iOS will ask you to Allow Tracking or Ask App Not to Track. Choose Ask App Not to Track for almost every app, every time.
❤ Health & Fitness	What it means The app can read or write data to Apple Health, steps, heart rate, sleep, weight, and other health metrics.	Allow when... Fitness trackers, health monitoring apps, medical apps. Deny for general wellness apps that do not have a specific, clear health purpose.

WARNING

Be especially cautious about granting Microphone and Contacts permissions. Microphone access in the wrong hands means an app could potentially listen to conversations near your phone. Contacts access means your friends' and family members' private details leave your device, without their knowledge or consent. Neither permission should be granted to any app that does not have an obvious, specific need for it.

How to do a full permissions audit

There are two ways to review your app permissions in iOS. The first is by permission type, seeing which apps have access to your location, for example. The second is by app, seeing everything a single app can access. We will do both.

- Method 1, Audit by permission type
- Settings path: Settings > Privacy & Security

This is your permissions control centre. Every permission category is listed here. Tap any one of them to see which apps have been granted that access.

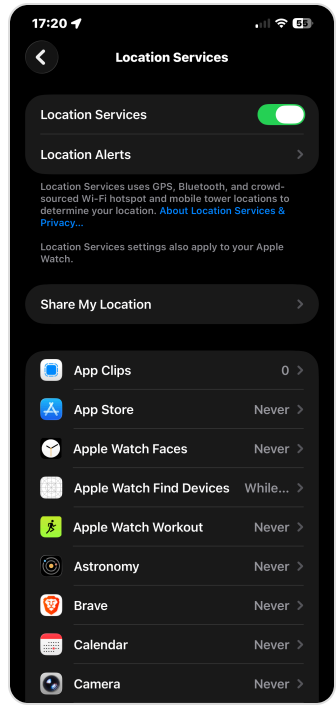
Open Settings and tap Privacy & Security.

Tap Location Services at the top of the list.

Review each app listed. The setting next to each app shows what level of access it has: Never, Ask Next Time, While Using, or Always.

Tap any app to change its location access. For most apps, While Using is the safest option if they need location at all.

Go back to Privacy & Security and repeat for Camera, Microphone, Contacts, and Photos.



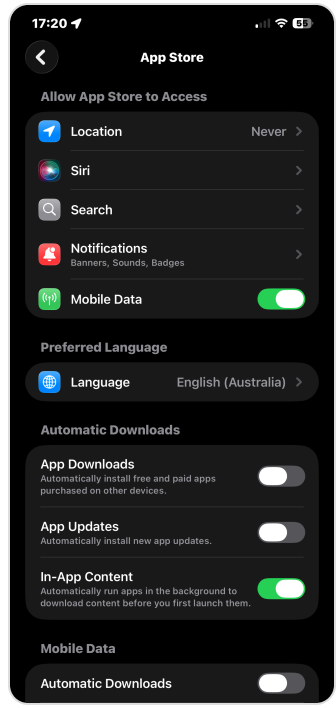
The Location Services screen shows every app with location access and what level they have been granted. 'Always' means the app can track your location even when you are not using it, this is rarely necessary.

> **TIP**
>
> Work through these five permissions in order: Location, Camera, Microphone, Contacts, Photos. For each one, ask yourself: does this app genuinely need this to work properly? If the answer is no, or if you are not sure, tap it and change it to Never. You can always grant it again later if the app asks for a legitimate reason.

- Method 2, Audit by individual app
- Settings path: Settings > [scroll down to the app name]

If you want to see everything a specific app can access, all in one place, scroll down past the standard Settings options until you reach the alphabetical list of your installed apps. Tap any app name to see

every permission it holds and toggle them on or off.



Tapping an app in Settings shows all its permissions in one place. This is the fastest way to review, or completely revoke, everything a single app can access.

This view is particularly useful for social media apps and games, which often accumulate a long list of permissions over time. It is common to find that a social media app has been granted access to your camera, microphone, contacts, location, and photo library, often because you tapped Allow years ago during a specific feature and forgot.

The App Privacy Report, seeing what apps are actually doing

iOS includes a feature called the App Privacy Report that goes beyond what permissions are granted, it shows you what apps are actually doing with them. This is genuinely powerful and almost nobody knows it exists.

When enabled, it keeps a running record of every time an app accesses your location, camera, microphone, contacts, or photos, and every third-party domain the app contacts over the network.

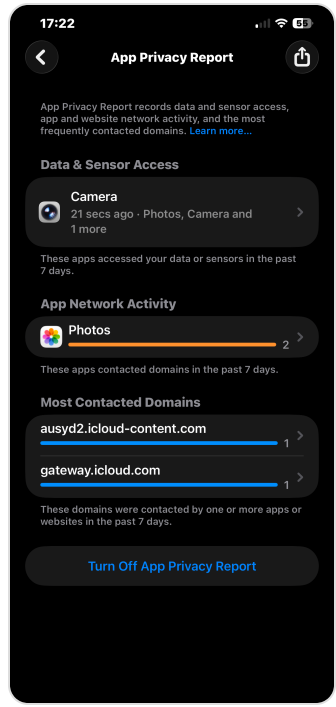
Settings›Privacy & Security›App Privacy Report

Open Settings and tap Privacy & Security.

Scroll down and tap App Privacy Report.

Tap Turn On App Privacy Report.

Wait 24–48 hours then return to this screen to see a full record of what your apps have been doing.



The App Privacy Report records every time an app accesses a sensitive permission and every external domain it connects to. Anything accessing your location or microphone frequently, especially when you are not actively using the app, deserves a closer look.

> **DID YOU KNOW?**
>
> The App Privacy Report does not block anything, it simply records it. Think of it as a security camera for your phone's permissions. If you see an app frequently accessing your location or microphone at odd hours, that is a strong signal to either revoke that permission or delete the app entirely.

Tracking, the one permission that deserves special attention

Tracking is different from the other permissions. It does not give an app access to a feature of your phone, instead, it allows the app to follow your activity across other apps and websites, building a detailed profile of your interests, habits, and behaviour that is then used for targeted advertising.

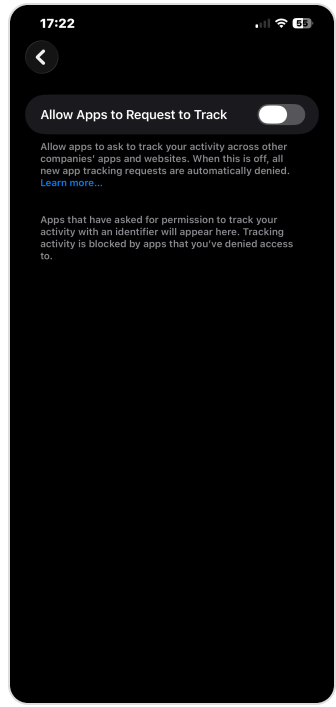
Apple introduced the App Tracking Transparency framework in 2021, which requires apps to ask your permission before tracking you. You can also set a default answer for all apps at once.

Settings›Privacy & Security›Tracking

Open Settings and tap Privacy & Security.

Tap Tracking.

Toggle off Allow Apps to Request to Track. This will automatically deny tracking requests from all apps without showing you the pop-up.



Turning off 'Allow Apps to Request to Track' means apps can no longer ask you for tracking permission, and any app that already had it will have that permission automatically revoked.

> **WELL DONE IF YOU HAVE THIS**
>
> Turning off tracking does not break any app functionality. It simply means the apps on your phone can no longer follow you around the internet building an advertising profile. The apps still work exactly as they should, you just see less targeted advertising, and your browsing habits stay private.

Which apps to look at most closely

- Not all apps carry equal risk. Here are the categories worth paying closest attention to during your audit:
- Free games

Free games are one of the most common sources of unnecessary permission grants. They frequently request location, contacts, and microphone access for features that have nothing to do with playing the game, often to serve targeted advertising. Review every free game on your phone and revoke everything that is not obviously needed.

Social media apps

Facebook, Instagram, TikTok, and similar apps are designed to collect as much data as possible. They will often hold camera, microphone, contacts, location, and photo library access simultaneously. For social media apps, consider granting only what you actively use, for example, camera access when you are posting a photo, and revoking the rest.

Shopping and retail apps

Shopping apps rarely need microphone or contact access. Location access While Using is reasonable if you are using store-finder features, but Always location access is not. Review these carefully.

Old or unused apps

The easiest permission to miss is one held by an app you no longer use. If you have not opened an app in more than three months, either delete it or revoke all its permissions. An unused app that still holds microphone access is a risk with no benefit.

> **TIP**
> iOS has a built-in feature to automatically revoke permissions from apps you haven't used in a while. To enable it: Settings > Privacy & Security > scroll to the bottom > ensure 'Revoke Permission for Unused Apps' (or similar wording) is toggled on. This runs quietly in the background and keeps your permissions list clean over time.

Quick review, your chapter 4 checklist

Set aside fifteen minutes with your iPhone and work through each of these. Tick them off as you go.

- I have reviewed Location Services and changed any 'Always' permissions to 'While Using' or 'Never' where appropriate
- I have reviewed Camera permissions and revoked access from any app that does not genuinely need it
- I have reviewed Microphone permissions and revoked access from games, shopping apps, and anything else that has no clear need to listen
- I have reviewed Contacts permissions and ensured only calling and messaging apps have access
- I have reviewed Photos permissions and switched any 'Full Access' grants to 'Selected Photos' where possible
- I have turned off 'Allow Apps to Request to Track' under Privacy & Security > Tracking
- I have turned on the App Privacy Report and will check it again in 48 hours

> **WELL DONE IF YOU HAVE THIS**
>
> Your apps can now only access what they genuinely need. The permissions audit is one of the most underrated privacy steps an iPhone user can take, and most people never do it. You now know more about what is on your phone than the majority of iPhone users in Australia.

What's next: Chapter 5 covers scams, fake texts, and phishing, the most common way attackers try to get into your phone and your accounts. We look at real Australian examples, teach you the red

flags that give scams away, and tell you exactly what to do if you think you have already clicked something you should not have.

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05

Scams, fake texts and phishing

How to spot them, what to do, and how to recover if you clicked

This is the chapter most people turn to first. And with good reason, scam messages, fake calls, and phishing links are by far the most common way Australians lose money and personal information online.

In 2023, Australians reported over $2.7 billion in losses to scams. The majority of those scams arrived by phone call or text message. And the majority of victims were not careless, they were targeted by professionals using convincing, well-designed deception.

This chapter shows you what the most common scams targeting Australian iPhone users actually look like, teaches you the red flags that give them away every time, and tells you exactly what to do, step by step, if you think you have already fallen for one. No judgement. Just practical help.

> **DID YOU KNOW?**
> The Australian Competition and Consumer Commission's Scamwatch (scamwatch.gov.au) is Australia's national scam reporting service. It publishes real-time data on current scams circulating in Australia and accepts reports from the public. It is worth bookmarking. Reporting a scam, even if you lost nothing, helps protect other Australians.

Why scams work, the psychology behind them

Understanding why scams work is the most important thing you can do to protect yourself. It is not about intelligence. It is about how the human brain responds to certain triggers, and scammers are expert at pulling those triggers.

The five psychological levers every scam uses:

Urgency, 'Your account will be closed in 24 hours.' Urgency bypasses careful thinking.

Authority, 'This is the ATO. You have an outstanding debt.' We are conditioned to comply with authority.

Fear, 'Your identity has been used in a crime.' Fear shuts down the rational brain.

Familiarity, The message looks exactly like one from your bank. Familiarity creates trust.

Reward, 'You have been selected for a $500 refund.' The promise of a gain lowers our guard.

Every scam you will ever encounter uses at least one of these levers, and usually two or three together. The moment you feel urgency, fear, or excitement about an unexpected message or call, that is the signal to slow down, not speed up.

> **TIP**
>
> The single most effective defence against scams is a three-second pause. Before clicking any link, calling back any number, or providing any information, stop. Ask yourself: did I initiate this contact? If the answer is no, treat it with significant caution regardless of how legitimate it appears.

The scams most likely to reach you

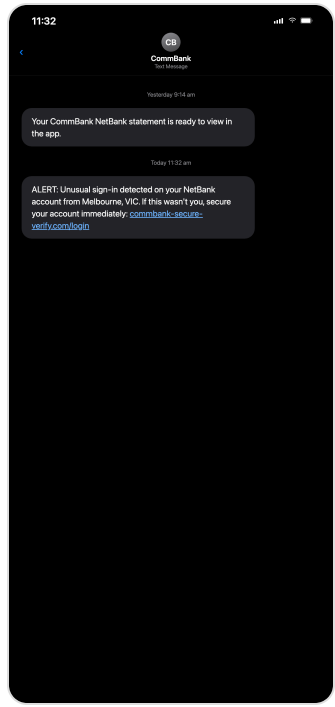
Here are the most common scam types currently targeting Australian iPhone users, with real examples of what they look like.

1 Bank impersonation scams

A text message or call appears to come from your bank, warning of suspicious activity on your account and asking you to verify your details or transfer money to a 'safe account'. This is the most financially damaging scam type in Australia.

> **CommBank**
> *“Unusual sign-in detected on your NetBank account from Melbourne, VIC. If this wasn't you, secure your account immediately: commbank-secure-verify.com/login”*

⚠ **Red flags:** fake domain (commbank-secure-verify.com is not commbank.com.au), urgency, unsolicited



Illustrative mockup, not real CommBank correspondence, built to show the pattern, not to reproduce their branding.

Scammers can 'spoof' the sender name on an SMS so it appears as 'CommBank' or 'myGov' in your messages list, even appearing in the same thread as genuine messages. The only reliable check is the link itself. Your bank's real domain ends in .com.au, never a variation like -secure-verify.com or -alerts.net.

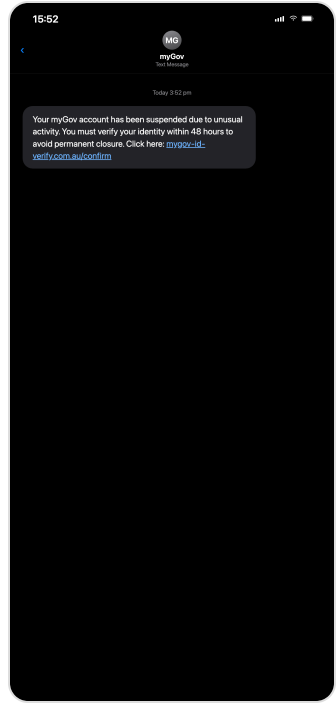
> **WARNING**
>
> Your bank will NEVER send you an SMS asking you to click a link and enter your full internet banking password, card number, or PIN. If you receive a message like this, do not click anything. Call your bank directly using the number on the back of your card or from their official website.

2 ATO and government impersonation scams

A call or message claiming to be from the Australian Taxation Office, myGov, Centrelink, or Medicare. The message typically claims you owe a tax debt, your Medicare details have been compromised, or your myGov account needs verification.

> **myGov**
> *"Your myGov account has been suspended due to unusual activity. You must verify your identity within 48 hours to avoid permanent closure. Click here: mygov-id-verify.com.au/confirm"*

⚠ **Red flags:** fake domain, artificial deadline, suspension threat, unsolicited



Illustrative mockup, not a real myGov message, built to show the pattern, not to reproduce their branding.

The ATO and myGov will never call you and demand immediate payment over the phone. They will never threaten arrest or legal action via SMS. If you receive a call from someone claiming to be the ATO and demanding immediate payment, hang up.

> **DID YOU KNOW?**
> The ATO has a dedicated scam reporting line: 1800 008 540. If you receive a suspicious ATO call or message, you can report it there. The ATO also has a 'check this ATO contact' tool at ato.gov.au where you can verify whether a communication is genuine before acting on it.

3 Australia Post and delivery scams

A text message claiming a parcel could not be delivered and asking you to click a link to reschedule, or pay a small fee. These scams are particularly effective because most people are expecting deliveries at any given time.

> **AusPost**
> *"Your parcel (AP29471882) could not be delivered. A $3.20 redelivery fee is required to release your package. Pay now: auspost-redelivery.com/pay"*

⚠ **Red flags:** fee request via link, fake domain, vague parcel reference, unsolicited

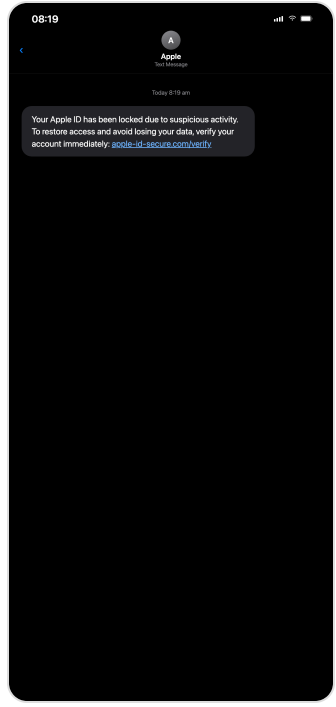
Australia Post will never ask you to pay a fee via a link in a text message. If you are expecting a parcel, go directly to auspost.com.au and use the tracking number you were given when you made your purchase, not a number provided in a message.

4 Apple ID and iCloud scams

A message or email claiming your Apple ID has been locked, that unusual purchases have been made, or that your iCloud storage is full and your account will be deleted. These are designed to look exactly like genuine Apple communications.

> **Apple**
> *“Your Apple ID has been locked due to suspicious activity. To restore access and avoid losing your data, verify your account immediately: apple-id-secure.com/verify”*

⚠ **Red flags:** fake domain, data loss threat, urgency, unsolicited, Apple emails from apple.com only



Illustrative mockup, not a real Apple message, built to show the pattern, not to reproduce their branding.

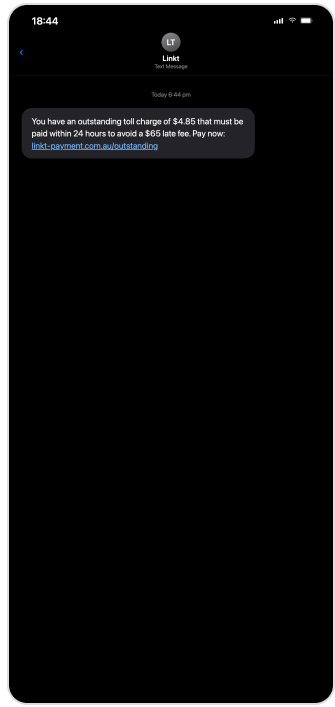
Genuine Apple communications always come from @apple.com email addresses. Apple will never contact you by SMS to tell you your Apple ID is locked, this is handled entirely through your device or through appleid.apple.com. If you are concerned, go directly to appleid.apple.com in a browser you typed yourself.

5 Toll road and fine scams

A message claiming you have an unpaid toll road charge or traffic fine, with a link to pay. These have surged in Australia since 2023 and are particularly convincing because toll charges are a normal part of life and the amounts are often small.

> **Linkt**
> *"You have an outstanding toll charge of $4.85 that must be paid within 24 hours to avoid a $65 late fee. Pay now: linkt-payment.com.au/outstanding"*

⚠ **Red flags:** fake domain, small amount designed to seem plausible, deadline threat, unsolicited



Illustrative mockup, not a real Linkt message, built to show the pattern, not to reproduce their branding.

If you use toll roads, log in to your account directly at the provider's official website, Linkt (linkt.com.au), EastLink (eastlink.com.au), or your state's relevant service. Never pay via a link in a text message.

6 Phone call scams, 'wangiri' and tech support

Two phone call scam types are particularly common in Australia right now.

Wangiri scams involve a single ring from an international number. If you call back, you are connected to a premium-rate line and charged a significant amount per minute. Do not return calls from numbers you do not recognise, especially international ones.

Tech support scams involve a caller claiming to be from Telstra, Microsoft, Apple, or 'your internet provider' saying your device has been hacked and offering to help. They will try to get you to install remote access software that gives them control of your phone or computer.

> **CRITICAL**
> Never allow anyone who calls you to install software on your device or take remote control. No legitimate technology company, not Apple, not Telstra, not Microsoft, will ever call you unsolicited to tell you your device has a problem and offer to fix it remotely. If someone calls you with this offer, hang up immediately. Remote access software in the wrong hands gives a stranger complete control of your device and everything on it, in real time, from anywhere in the world.

The universal red flag checklist

Every scam, regardless of who it claims to be from, shares the same warning signs. Learn these and you will be able to identify a scam within seconds of receiving it.

You did not initiate the contact. If you did not call them, email them, or ask to be contacted, be suspicious of anyone contacting you, regardless of who they claim to be.

There is a deadline or urgent threat. 'You have 24 hours', 'your account will be closed', 'you will be arrested'. Urgency is a manipulation tool. Legitimate organisations give you time.

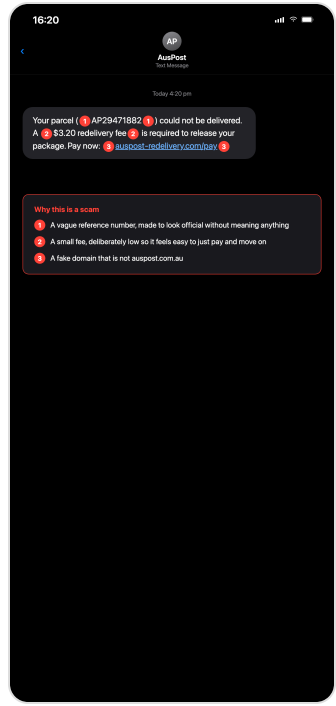
The link does not match the organisation. A genuine CommBank link ends in commbank.com.au. A genuine ATO link ends in ato.gov.au. Anything else, commbank-alerts.net, ato-id-verify.com, is fake.

You are asked to pay in an unusual way. Gift cards, cryptocurrency, wire transfers, or 'safe accounts' are never requested by legitimate organisations. Ever.

You are asked to keep it secret. 'Do not tell your family about this.' 'This is a confidential investigation.' Legitimate organisations never ask you to hide contact from people you trust.

The greeting is generic. 'Dear Customer', 'Dear Account Holder'. Your bank knows your name. Generic greetings suggest a mass-sent scam.

You feel scared, excited, or pressured. These feelings are the scammer working. When you feel them, slow down, do not speed up.



A single scam message can contain multiple red flags simultaneously. Learning to spot even one is enough to protect yourself, you do not need to identify every flaw, just enough to pause and verify independently.

How to verify any suspicious message

If you receive a message and are not sure whether it is genuine, here is the safest process to follow every time.

Do not click any links in the message, and do not call any number provided in it.

Find the organisation's real contact details by going to their official website (type it yourself in Safari, do not use a link from the message) or by looking at the back of your card, a previous statement, or the phone book.

Contact the organisation directly using those independently found details and ask whether the communication was genuine.

If they confirm it was not genuine, report it to Scamwatch at scamwatch.gov.au and to the organisation being impersonated.

> **TIP**
> Save these numbers in your phone right now, before you need them: Your bank's fraud line, found on the back of your card. Scamwatch reporting: visit scamwatch.gov.au or call the ACCC on 1300 302 502. IDCARE (identity theft support): 1800 595 160, free service for Australians. Having these ready means you can act quickly if something does go wrong.

Protecting yourself inside the Messages app

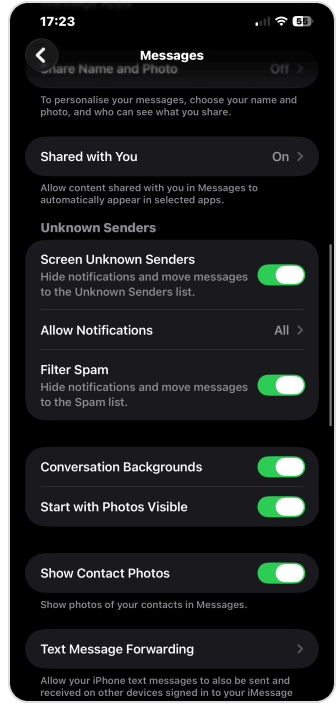
iOS has built-in tools to help filter scam messages before they reach you. Here is how to turn them on.

- Filter unknown senders
- Settings path: Settings > Apps > Messages > Screen Unknown Senders

When this is turned on, messages from people not in your contacts are moved to a separate 'Unknown Senders' tab and cannot send you notifications. This does not block messages, you can still read them, but it removes the urgency and surprise that scammers rely on. iOS also offers a separate Filter Spam toggle in the same section, worth turning on alongside it.

Open Settings and scroll down to Apps, then tap Messages.

Toggle on Screen Unknown Senders (this setting was called Filter Unknown Senders in older versions of iOS).

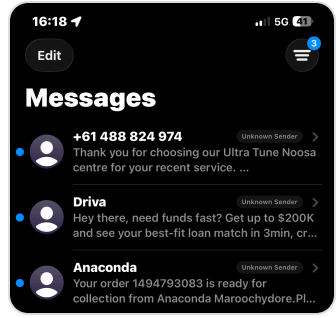


Screen Unknown Senders moves messages from people not in your contacts into a separate filtered tab. You can still read them, but they no longer interrupt you with notifications.

Report junk messages

On some iPhones, a Report Junk link appears at the bottom of a conversation from an unknown sender, below the messages themselves, not in the contact card you get by tapping the sender's number. Tapping it sends a copy to Apple, deletes the message, and blocks the sender.

Whether you see this option depends on your carrier and how the message arrived. It is most reliable for iMessages (blue bubble) from an unknown sender, and is not available on every Australian carrier for standard text messages (green bubble). If you do not see it, do not worry, it is a bonus, not something to chase. Everything else in this chapter, especially Screen Unknown Senders, works regardless.



With Screen Unknown Senders on, messages from numbers not in your contacts are clearly tagged "Unknown Sender" right in your message list. The "Driva" message here is a good real-world example of the kind of unsolicited loan-spam text this chapter warns about. If a Report Junk link happens to be available for a particular message, you'll find it at the bottom of that conversation.

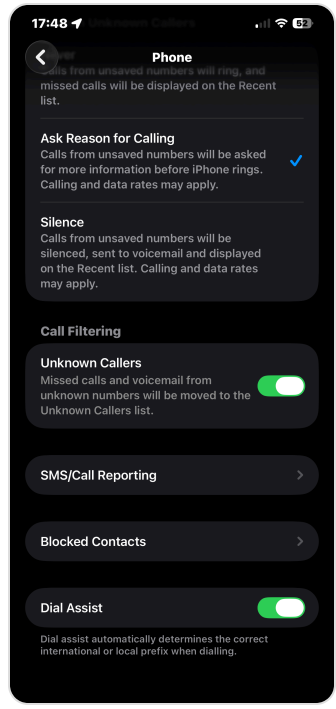
- Silence unknown callers

- Settings path: Settings > Apps > Phone > Screen Unknown Callers

Current iOS offers three choices for calls from numbers not in your contacts, your recent calls, or Siri Suggestions: Never (they ring normally), Ask Reason for Calling (the caller is asked to state their name or reason before your phone rings), and Silence (they go straight to voicemail). Legitimate callers, a doctor's office, a tradesperson, a new contact, will leave a message or state their reason. Scammers almost never do.

Open Settings and scroll to Apps, then tap Phone.

Choose Ask Reason for Calling or Silence, whichever you prefer. Ask Reason for Calling is a good middle ground, since it still lets your phone ring for a genuine caller who responds. Also turn on Unknown Callers under Call Filtering, which moves missed calls and voicemail from unknown numbers to a separate list.



Screen Unknown Callers is one of the most effective tools for reducing scam phone calls. With Ask Reason for Calling or Silence selected, calls from unknown numbers no longer ring through unfiltered, giving you time to verify who is calling before responding.

> **WELL DONE IF YOU HAVE THIS**
>
> With Screen Unknown Senders and Screen Unknown Callers both turned on, the vast majority of scam messages and calls will be automatically filtered before they reach you. This does not block legitimate contacts, it simply removes the element of surprise that scammers depend on to be effective.

What to do if you think you clicked something you should not have

First, and this is important, do not panic, and do not be embarrassed. This happens to people of all backgrounds and levels of experience. What matters now is acting quickly and calmly.

Follow these steps in order.

If you clicked a link but did not enter any information

Close Safari immediately.

Clear your browsing history: Settings > Apps > Safari > Clear History and Website Data.

Run a quick check of your Apple ID sign-in activity: Settings > [Your Name] > look for any unrecognised devices.

Change your Apple ID password as a precaution, see Chapter 3 for steps.

Monitor your accounts over the next 48 hours for any unusual activity.

If you entered personal information or banking details

Call your bank immediately using the number on the back of your card. Tell them exactly what happened and ask them to monitor your account for unusual transactions. Do this before anything else.

Change your internet banking password from a different device if possible.

Change your Apple ID password , see Chapter 3.

Contact IDCARE at idcare.org or call 1800 595 160. They are Australia's national identity and cyber support service and can guide you through next steps for free.

Report the scam to Scamwatch at scamwatch.gov.au. Your report helps protect other Australians.

Consider placing a credit alert on your credit file to prevent new accounts being opened in your name. Contact Equifax (equifax.com.au) or illion (illion.com.au) for details.

> **WARNING**
> Do not wait to see if anything happens before calling your bank. Fraudulent transactions can be processed within minutes of a scammer obtaining your details. The faster you call, the better the chance your bank can stop or reverse the transaction.

If you gave someone remote access to your phone

Remove the remote access app immediately. Find it on your home screen or in Settings > General > VPN & Device Management and delete it.

Call your bank and ask them to freeze your accounts until you have confirmed no fraudulent activity.

Change every password on your phone, starting with your Apple ID and internet banking, from a different device.

Contact IDCARE immediately on 1800 595 160. This is one of the more serious situations and professional guidance is strongly recommended.

Consider a factory reset of your iPhone if you have any doubt about what the scammer may have installed. Your data is safely backed up in iCloud, see Chapter 3.

Quick review, your chapter 5 checklist

- I know the five psychological triggers scammers use and can recognise them
- I know the seven universal red flags of a scam message or call

- I have saved my bank's fraud line number in my phone contacts
- I have turned on Screen Unknown Senders in Messages settings
- I have turned on Screen Unknown Callers in Phone settings
- I know what to do, and who to call, if I ever click something I should not have
- I know that IDCARE (1800 595 160) provides free help for Australians affected by scams

> **WELL DONE IF YOU HAVE THIS**
>
> Scam awareness is a skill that compounds. The more you practise spotting red flags, the faster and more automatic it becomes. Share what you have learned in this chapter with someone you care about, a friend, a family member, a neighbour. Every person who knows these signs is one fewer person a scammer can harm.

What's next: Chapter 6 covers Wi-Fi and VPN, how to stay safe when using the internet away from home, what a VPN actually does in plain English, and the simple steps that protect you on public networks in cafés, airports, and shopping centres.

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06

Wi-Fi and VPN

Staying safe on public networks, and what a VPN actually does

Most of us connect to Wi-Fi without thinking much about it. At a café, a hotel, an airport, a library, you see the network name, enter the password (or find it on a sign), and you are online. Simple.

But public Wi-Fi networks carry risks that your home network does not. And some of the settings on your iPhone that seem harmless, like automatically joining known networks, can actually expose you in ways that are not immediately obvious.

This chapter explains how Wi-Fi security works in plain English, what the real risks of public networks are (and are not), how to configure your iPhone to connect safely, and what a VPN is and when it is genuinely worth using.

SOUNDS FAMILIAR?

A retired teacher from the Gold Coast was at a shopping centre café, using the free Wi-Fi to check her bank balance and pay a bill online. The network name was 'CafeWifi_Free', identical to the name on the sign at the counter. What she did not know was that a second network with the same name had been set up nearby by someone with a laptop and basic software. Her internet traffic passed through that device before reaching the internet. Her banking session was visible. She was not hacked that day, but she easily could have been. This is called an 'evil twin' attack. It costs almost nothing to set up and is alarmingly common.

This is a composite example, illustrating a well-documented attack technique, not a specific real person. If it sounds familiar, that's exactly the point.

How public Wi-Fi works, and where the risk actually is

When you connect to a Wi-Fi network, your iPhone sends and receives data through that network's router, the box that connects the network to the internet. On a public network, that router is controlled by someone else, and in some cases, the 'router' is actually another person's device set up to intercept traffic.

The risk on public Wi-Fi is not that someone will magically break into your iPhone. It is that unencrypted data, information travelling between your phone and the internet without protection, can potentially be seen by anyone on the same network.

The good news is that most of this risk has been significantly reduced by a technology called HTTPS, the padlock you see in your browser's address bar. When a website uses HTTPS, the data

between your phone and that website is encrypted, even on public Wi-Fi. Most major websites and apps now use HTTPS by default.

> **DID YOU KNOW?**
> HTTPS stands for HyperText Transfer Protocol Secure. When you visit a website that starts with https:// (or shows a padlock icon in Safari), your connection to that site is encrypted. This means even if someone intercepts your traffic on public Wi-Fi, they see scrambled data rather than readable information. The padlock is your first line of Wi-Fi defence. If a site shows 'Not Secure' in Safari, treat anything you type there as potentially visible.

So what are the genuine risks on public Wi-Fi today? Two main things:

Evil twin networks, fake Wi-Fi hotspots that impersonate legitimate ones, intercepting your traffic before passing it on. As in the story above, these can be created quickly and cheaply anywhere.

Unencrypted apps and older websites, some apps and websites still do not use HTTPS, meaning data sent through them on public Wi-Fi is readable by anyone on the same network.

The good news: both of these risks are manageable with a few simple habits and settings.

The risks of auto-join and known networks

Your iPhone keeps a list of every Wi-Fi network you have ever connected to. By default, when one of those networks is within range, your phone joins it automatically, without asking you.

This is convenient at home. But it creates a problem in public: if someone creates a fake network with the same name as one you have connected to before, say, 'Telstra Air' or 'McDonald's Free

WiFi', your phone may join it automatically without you noticing.

- How to manage auto-join for saved networks
- Settings path: Settings > Wi-Fi > tap the (i) next to any saved network

For any public network you have saved, cafes, hotels, shopping centres, airports, it is worth turning off Auto-Join. This means your phone will not connect to that network again without you explicitly choosing it.

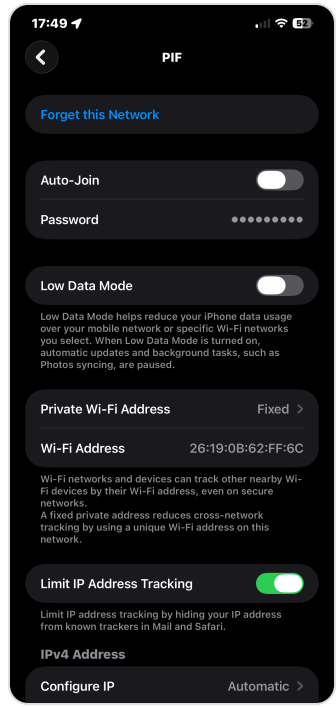
Open Settings and tap Wi-Fi.

Find a saved public network in the list (any network with a checkmark that you connected to outside your home).

Tap the blue (i) icon to the right of the network name.

Toggle off Auto-Join.

Repeat for all public networks in your saved list.



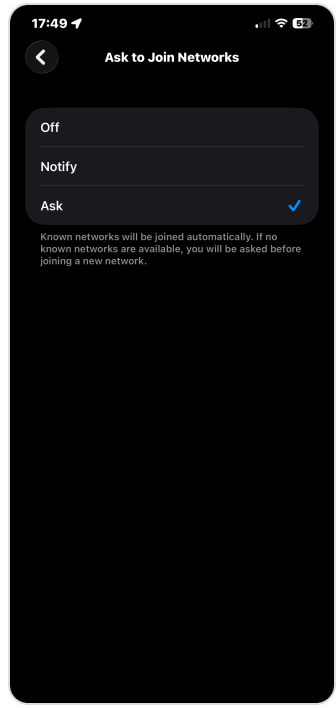
The network detail screen for a saved public Wi-Fi network. Turning off Auto-Join means your phone will not silently connect to this network, or a fake version of it, without your knowledge.

> **TIP**
>
> Your home and work networks are the only ones worth keeping Auto-Join turned on for. For every other saved network, cafés, gyms, hotels, airports, turn Auto-Join off. You can still connect to them when you choose; your phone just will not do it silently.

- Ask to join networks
- Settings path: Settings > Wi-Fi > Ask to Join Networks

This setting controls whether your iPhone asks before joining new networks it has not seen before. The recommended setting is Ask, this way your phone prompts you rather than automatically

connecting to any open network it finds.



With 'Ask to Join Networks' set to Ask, your iPhone will prompt you before connecting to any new network, giving you a moment to consider whether you actually want to join it.

Safe habits on public Wi-Fi

Good Wi-Fi security is less about technical settings and more about simple habits. Here are the ones that make the biggest difference.

⚠ Risky behaviour	✓ Safer choice
Logging in to your bank on café Wi-Fi without a VPN	Use mobile data (4G/5G) for banking, it is significantly more secure than public Wi-Fi
Staying connected to public Wi-Fi all day without thinking about it	Connect only when you need it, then turn Wi-Fi off or switch back to mobile data
Joining any open network with a familiar-sounding name	Check the exact network name with a staff member before connecting
Shopping online and entering card details on public Wi-Fi	Save online shopping for your home network or use Apple Pay, which does not transmit your card number
Assuming the padlock icon means the website is trustworthy	The padlock means the connection is encrypted, not that the site itself is legitimate. Scam sites can have padlocks too.
Using the same Wi-Fi password at home for years	Change your home Wi-Fi password every 12–18 months and use WPA3 or WPA2 security if your router supports it

WARNING

The single highest-risk activity on public Wi-Fi is mobile banking. Even with HTTPS, the combination of an unknown network, a potentially intercepted connection, and a banking session is a risk not worth taking. Use your mobile data, 4G or 5G, for banking when you are away from home. It is encrypted end-to-end and does not pass through a shared public router.

Your home Wi-Fi, the settings worth checking

Your home network is generally much safer than public Wi-Fi, but only if it is configured correctly. Here are the settings on your home router worth verifying.

Use a strong, unique Wi-Fi password

Your home Wi-Fi password should be at least 12 characters, not a word from the dictionary, and not the default password printed on the back of your router. Default passwords are publicly listed for most router models and are one of the first things someone will try.

To change your Wi-Fi password, log in to your router's admin page, usually by typing 192.168.0.1 or 192.168.1.1 into a browser on your home network. Your router's manual or your internet service provider can guide you through this.

Use WPA3 or WPA2 security

Wi-Fi networks can use different security protocols, the system that encrypts your wireless traffic. WPA3 is the current standard and the most secure. WPA2 is also acceptable. WEP and WPA (without the number) are older, weaker, and should be avoided if possible.

Check your router's security setting in its admin page and upgrade to WPA3 or WPA2 if you are using an older protocol.

Set up a guest network for visitors

Most modern routers allow you to create a separate guest Wi-Fi network, a second network that visitors can use without being able to access your main network or the devices on it. This is particularly useful if you have smart home devices, a printer, or a computer connected to your home network that you would rather keep separate from guest devices.

Check your router's app or admin page for a Guest Network option. It usually takes under five minutes to set up.

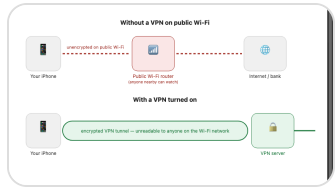
> **TIP**
> Smart home devices, TVs, doorbells, thermostats, robot vacuums, are often less securely built than phones and computers. Putting them on a guest network keeps them isolated from your phone, laptop, and any sensitive data on your main network. This is called network segmentation, and it is one of the smartest home security steps most people have never heard of.

What is a VPN, in plain English

VPN stands for Virtual Private Network. It sounds technical, but the concept is simple.

Normally, when your iPhone sends data to the internet, that data travels from your phone, through whatever network you are on (home Wi-Fi, café Wi-Fi, or mobile data), and out to the website or app you are using. Anyone who can see the traffic on that network can potentially see what you are doing, though HTTPS limits how much they can actually read.

- A VPN adds a layer to this journey. It creates an encrypted tunnel between your phone and a server operated by the VPN provider. All your traffic travels through that tunnel before going to the internet. This means:
- Anyone on the same Wi-Fi network as you sees only encrypted tunnel traffic, not what you are actually doing
- The website or app you are visiting sees the VPN server's location, not your actual location
- Your internet service provider cannot see your browsing activity



A VPN creates an encrypted tunnel between your phone and a server, so anyone monitoring the network between you and the internet sees only scrambled data. Think of it as a private, sealed pipe through a public space.

- When a VPN is genuinely useful
- Using public Wi-Fi in cafés, airports, hotels, or shopping centres, especially for anything sensitive
- Travelling overseas and wanting to access Australian services
- Adding an extra layer of privacy on your home network
- Using banking or financial apps away from your home network
- When a VPN is not the answer
- A VPN does not protect you from phishing, clicking a scam link still takes you to the scam site
- A VPN does not replace a strong passcode or two-factor authentication
- A VPN does not make an untrustworthy website trustworthy
- A free VPN is often worse than no VPN, many free VPN services make money by logging and selling your browsing data, which defeats the purpose entirely

WARNING

Never use a free VPN from an unknown provider. Free VPNs have to make money somehow, and many do it by recording everything you do and selling that data to advertisers or third parties. A paid VPN from a reputable provider costs less than a coffee per week and does not harvest your data. The free ones often do the opposite of what you want.

Which VPN to choose, a plain-English comparison

There are hundreds of VPN providers. Here are four reputable options suitable for everyday Australian iPhone users, compared simply.

VPN Provider	Cost	Best for
Mullvad	~AU$8/mo	Privacy-first, no account required, no logs, accepts cash payment. Best for maximum anonymity.
ProtonVPN	Free tier / ~AU$12/mo	Swiss-based, strong privacy laws, free tier available with limited servers. Good for everyday use.
ExpressVPN	~AU$15/mo	Very fast, easy to use, good Australian server coverage. Best for streaming and travel.
NordVPN	~AU$7/mo (annual)	Popular, reliable, good value on annual plan. Solid choice for most everyday users.

How to install and use a VPN on your iPhone

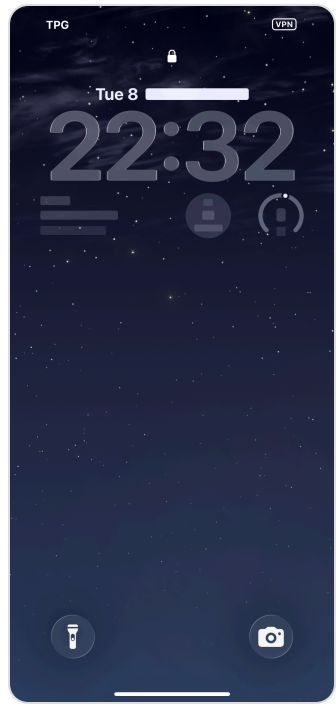
Choose a VPN provider from the table above and subscribe via their official website.

Download their iPhone app from the App Store, search for the provider name and look for the official app.

Open the app and sign in with the account you created.

Tap Connect to start the VPN. A VPN icon (a small box with a key) will appear in your status bar when it is active.

Use the VPN whenever you are on public Wi-Fi. Most VPN apps have an Auto-Connect on Untrusted Networks setting, enable this so the VPN turns on automatically whenever you join a public network.



When a VPN is active, a small 'VPN' label appears in your iPhone's status bar. This confirms your traffic is travelling through the encrypted tunnel.

WELL DONE IF YOU HAVE THIS

A VPN running on public Wi-Fi, combined with HTTPS websites and mobile data for banking, covers the vast majority of real-world Wi-Fi security risks. You do not need to be connected to a VPN at home on your own secured network, save it for when you are out and about, and make it automatic on public networks.

Quick review, your chapter 6 checklist

- I have reviewed my saved Wi-Fi networks and turned off Auto-Join for all public networks
- My Ask to Join Networks setting is set to Ask
- I use mobile data (4G/5G) rather than public Wi-Fi when accessing my bank or making payments away from home
- My home Wi-Fi uses a strong, unique password (not the default router password)
- I have considered setting up a guest network for visitors and smart home devices
- I understand what a VPN does and have either installed one or noted it as a next step
- I know never to use a free VPN from an unknown provider

> **WELL DONE IF YOU HAVE THIS**
>
> Your Wi-Fi habits and settings are now significantly stronger. Most people never think about this until something goes wrong. The combination of good habits, mobile data for banking, auto-join off, a reputable VPN on public networks, is more than enough for everyday protection.

What's next: Chapter 7 covers what to do if your iPhone is ever lost or stolen, setting up Find My correctly, understanding Activation Lock, and the step-by-step actions to take in the critical first thirty minutes after your phone goes missing.

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07

Find My and what to do if stolen

Setting up your safety net before you ever need it

There is a particular kind of panic that comes with realising your phone is missing, patting your pockets, retracing your steps, that sinking feeling as the seconds tick by. It happens to almost everyone at some point.

The difference between a stressful but manageable situation and a genuine crisis comes down to one thing: whether you set up Find My iPhone before it happened.

This chapter walks you through setting up Find My properly, explains Activation Lock, the feature that makes a stolen iPhone essentially worthless to a thief, and gives you a clear, calm, step-by-step plan for exactly what to do in the first thirty minutes after your phone goes missing.

SOUNDS FAMILIAR?

A man in his seventies left his iPhone on a café table in Noosa while paying at the counter. By the time he turned around, it was gone. Because Find My was set up and his iPhone was linked to his Apple ID with two-factor authentication active, he was able to open Find My on his wife's iPad within minutes. He saw his phone moving along the highway toward Eumundi. He reported it to police with the live location, marked the phone as Lost, and it was recovered within two hours. Without Find My set up in advance, this would have been a permanent loss of the device and everything on it.

This is a composite example, not a specific real person, though a version of this happens to someone on the Sunshine Coast most weeks.

Setting up Find My, before you need it

Find My is Apple's location and device protection service. It needs to be set up in advance, there is no way to activate it after a phone has already been lost or stolen. This is why this chapter matters even if your phone has never gone missing. Today is the day to set it up.

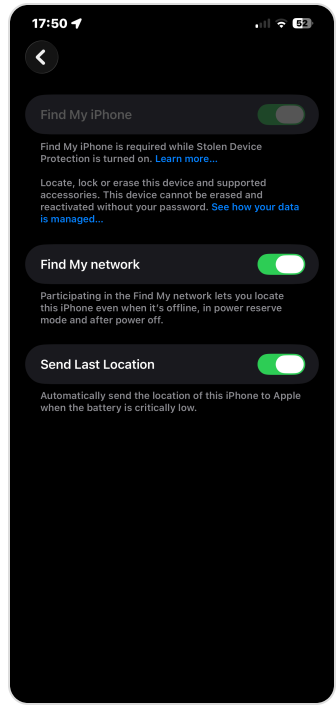
- Checking if Find My is already on
- Settings path: Settings > [Your Name] > Find My

Open Settings and tap your name at the top.

Tap Find My.

Tap Find My iPhone.

Confirm Find My iPhone is toggled ON. Also ensure Find My Network and Send Last Location are both toggled on.



All three settings should be green (on): Find My iPhone, Find My network, and Send Last Location. Together these give you the best chance of locating a missing device.

> **DID YOU KNOW?**
>
> Find My Network is what makes Apple's tracking so effective. Even if your iPhone is offline, switched off or out of battery, nearby Apple devices belonging to other people can anonymously detect your phone's Bluetooth signal and relay its location to you, without those other people ever knowing. This works through hundreds of millions of Apple devices worldwide and is encrypted so no one, including Apple, can see the data.

Send Last Location

This setting ensures that when your iPhone's battery is critically low, it automatically sends its current location to Apple's servers just before powering off. This means even if the phone dies, you still

have its last known location to work from, often the single most useful piece of information when something goes missing.

Activation Lock, why a stolen iPhone is worthless to a thief

Activation Lock is one of the most important security features Apple has ever built, and it is the reason iPhone theft rates have dropped significantly since its introduction. It is turned on automatically the moment you enable Find My iPhone, there is nothing extra to set up.

Here is what it does: once Activation Lock is active, your Apple ID and password are required before anyone can erase the device, turn off Find My, or set up the iPhone with a different Apple ID. This is true even if the thief performs a full factory reset.

In practice, this means a stolen iPhone cannot be wiped and resold as a working device. It becomes a locked, unusable object, which is precisely why iPhone theft has become a less attractive crime than it once was, and why so many stolen iPhones end up discarded rather than sold.

> **WELL DONE IF YOU HAVE THIS**
>
> If Find My iPhone is turned on (which you just confirmed above), Activation Lock is already protecting your device. You do not need to do anything further to activate it. This is one of the few security features that works entirely in the background.

> **WARNING**
> Never turn off Find My iPhone or sign out of your Apple ID for someone else, even if they claim to be a buyer who needs it off to 'test the phone' before purchasing. This is a common scam used to remove Activation Lock from a phone before it is stolen or to trick sellers into unlocking a device that will then be taken without payment.

Setting up Medical ID and emergency information

While we are in the safety settings, it is worth setting up one more feature that has nothing to do with theft but matters just as much, Medical ID. This allows emergency responders to see critical medical information and emergency contacts even when your phone is locked, by tapping Emergency on the lock screen.

Health app›tap your profile picture›Medical ID›Edit

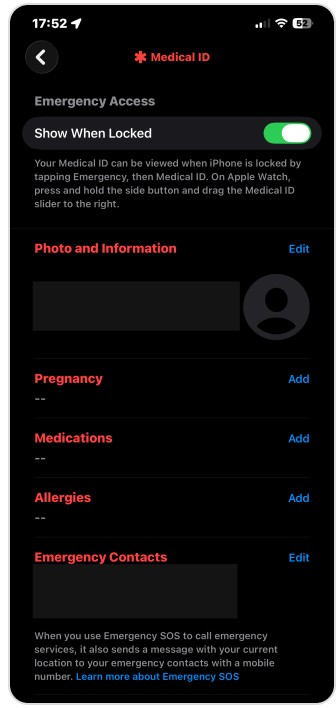
Open the Health app (a white icon with a red heart) and tap your profile picture in the top right.

Tap Medical ID, then tap Edit.

Add any medical conditions, allergies, and medications.

Add at least one emergency contact , ideally a family member who could be reached quickly.

Ensure Show When Locked is toggled ON, so this information is visible to first responders without needing to unlock your phone.



Medical ID information is visible from the lock screen by tapping 'Emergency', without needing your passcode. This can be genuinely life-saving information for first responders in an emergency.

> **TIP**
>
> If you have a family member or carer who should be contacted in an emergency, add them as your emergency contact here. This is separate from your regular contacts list and is specifically designed to be visible to paramedics and emergency services without unlocking your phone.

The first thirty minutes, what to do if your iPhone goes missing

If your phone is ever lost or stolen, the steps below are designed to be followed calmly, in order, using another device, a family member's phone, a laptop, or any computer with internet access.

Time	What to do
0–5 min	Use Find My on another device. Go to icloud.com/find on any web browser, or open the Find My app on another Apple device signed in to a family member's account that has you added as a shared user. Sign in with your Apple ID and locate your iPhone on the map.
5–10 min	Choose the right action. If the map shows your phone at a specific, stationary location (like your home or a friend's house), it may simply be misplaced. If it is moving, or in an unfamiliar location, it is more likely lost or stolen.
10–15 min	Mark as Lost. Tap 'Mark as Lost' in Find My. This locks your iPhone remotely with your passcode, displays a custom message and phone number on the lock screen, and disables Apple Pay so it cannot be used to make purchases.
15–20 min	Play Sound (if nearby). If you believe the phone is nearby, at home, in the car, down the back of the couch, use the 'Play Sound' feature in Find My, which makes the phone ring loudly even if it is on silent.
20–25 min	Notify your bank. If your iPhone had Apple Pay set up with your cards, call your bank to flag this. Marking the phone as Lost already disables Apple Pay, but it is worth confirming with your bank directly.
25–30 min	Report to police if stolen. If you believe the phone was stolen rather than lost, report it to police with the location information from Find My. Provide your phone's IMEI number if you have it recorded (see tip below).

> **TIP**
> Find your iPhone's IMEI number now and save it somewhere safe, a note in a password manager, a photo of it, or written down in a safe place. You will need it if you ever have to report a theft to police. Find it at: Settings > General > About > scroll to IMEI. You can also find it printed on the original box your iPhone came in.

What if you cannot find your phone at all?

If after following the steps above your phone is still missing and you believe it will not be recovered, here is what to do next.

Erase your iPhone remotely

If your phone contains sensitive information and you are confident it will not be recovered, you can erase it completely from Find My. This removes all your data from the device, but because Activation Lock remains active, the phone still cannot be used or resold by whoever has it.

Find My (on another device)›select your iPhone›Erase This Device

> **WARNING**
> Once you erase a device, Find My can no longer track its location, since the erase process also removes the Find My connection. Only erase your device after you have exhausted attempts to locate it, or if it contains highly sensitive information that you need to protect immediately.

Remove the device from your Apple ID

Once you have a replacement iPhone, you can remove the old one from your list of trusted devices to keep your account clean. See Chapter 3 for instructions on reviewing devices signed in to your

Apple ID.

Restore your new iPhone from iCloud backup

If you set up regular iCloud backups as described in Chapter 3, restoring a new iPhone is straightforward. During setup, choose Restore from iCloud Backup and select your most recent backup. Your photos, contacts, messages, and most app data will be restored automatically.

A note on insurance

- Find My and Activation Lock protect your data and make a stolen phone unusable to a thief, but they do not get your physical device back into your hands for free. If you do not already have insurance for your iPhone, it is worth checking whether it is covered under:
- Your home and contents insurance policy, many policies cover mobile phones, sometimes with a specific limit
- Your private health fund's extras cover, uncommon, but worth checking
- A dedicated mobile phone insurance policy through Apple (AppleCare+) or a third-party insurer
- Some Australian banks' everyday transaction or credit card accounts, which occasionally include device protection as a benefit

It is worth checking your current policies today, rather than discovering after the fact that you are not covered.

Quick review, your chapter 7 checklist

- Find My iPhone is turned ON, with Find My Network and Send Last Location also enabled
- I understand that Activation Lock is already protecting my device automatically
- I have set up Medical ID with emergency contact information
- I know where to find my iPhone's IMEI number and have saved it somewhere safe
- I know the steps to take in the first 30 minutes if my phone goes missing
- I have checked whether my iPhone is covered by insurance

> **WELL DONE IF YOU HAVE THIS**
> Your iPhone now has a complete safety net. If it is ever lost or stolen, you have a calm, clear plan to follow, and the technology working in the background to make the device useless to anyone but you. This is genuinely one of the most reassuring chapters in this book to have actioned.

What's next: In the final chapter, we bring everything together into a simple 15-minute monthly security checkup, a routine you can follow for years to come to make sure your iPhone stays protected as settings change, apps update, and new threats emerge.

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08

Your 15-minute security checkup

A simple monthly routine to keep your iPhone protected for years to come

Congratulations, if you have worked through every chapter in this book, your iPhone is now significantly more secure than it was when you started. You have a strong passcode, Face ID, Stolen Device Protection, a secured Apple ID, audited app permissions, scam awareness, safe Wi-Fi habits, and a complete plan if your phone is ever lost or stolen.

But security is not a one-time task. Apps update. New scams emerge. Settings occasionally reset after a software update. The single most effective thing you can do to maintain everything you have just built is a short, regular checkup.

This final chapter brings every chapter together into one simple page you can return to every month. It takes about fifteen minutes, start to finish.

> **DID YOU KNOW?**
> Set a recurring reminder right now, the first Sunday of every month works well for most people. Open the Reminders app, create a new reminder called 'iPhone security checkup', and set it to repeat monthly. This is the single most important step in this chapter: the checklist only works if you actually come back to it.

The complete monthly checklist

Work through this list with your iPhone in hand. Each item references the chapter where you can find full instructions if you need a refresher.

The front door, passcode & Face ID

✓	Task	Reference
☐	My passcode is still a strong Custom Alphanumeric or long numeric code	Ch. 2
☐	Face ID is working correctly and unlocks reliably	Ch. 2
☐	Auto-Lock is still set to 30 seconds or 1 minute	Ch. 2
☐	Stolen Device Protection is still turned ON	Ch. 2

Apple ID & iCloud

✓	Task	Reference
☐	Two-factor authentication is still active on my Apple ID	Ch. 3
☐	iCloud Backup shows a successful backup within the last week	Ch. 3
☐	I have reviewed the devices signed in to my Apple ID for anything unfamiliar	Ch. 3

App permissions

✓	Task	Reference
☐	I have reviewed any new apps installed this month and checked their permissions	Ch. 4
☐	App Privacy Report shows nothing unusual or unexpected	Ch. 4
☐	I have deleted any apps I have not used in the last three months	Ch. 4

Scam awareness

✓	Task	Reference
☐	Screen Unknown Senders and Screen Unknown Callers are still turned on	Ch. 5
☐	I have not clicked any suspicious links this month, and if I have, I followed the recovery steps	Ch. 5

Wi-Fi & VPN

✓	Task	Reference
☐	Auto-Join remains off for all public Wi-Fi networks	Ch. 6
☐	My VPN app is up to date and connects automatically on public networks	Ch. 6

Find My & emergency info

✓	Task	Reference
☐	Find My iPhone is still turned on with Find My Network and Send Last Location active	Ch. 7
☐	Medical ID information is current and emergency contact is correct	Ch. 7

General software health

✓	Task	Reference
□	My iPhone is running the latest version of iOS	New
□	All my apps are updated to their latest versions	New

Two new habits worth adding

Keeping iOS up to date

Apple regularly releases iOS updates that patch newly discovered security vulnerabilities. Running an outdated version of iOS means your phone may be missing protection against threats that have already been fixed for everyone who has updated.

Settings›General›Software Update

Check this screen during your monthly review. If an update is available, connect to Wi-Fi, plug your phone in to charge, and install it. For convenience, you can also turn on Automatic Updates so your phone installs important updates overnight without you needing to remember.

> **TIP**
> Settings > General > Software Update > Automatic Updates. Turn on both 'Install iOS Updates' and 'Security Responses & System Files'. Your phone will then install critical security updates automatically, usually overnight while charging, no action needed from you.

Keeping your apps up to date

App updates often include security fixes in addition to new features. By default, most iPhones update apps automatically, but it is worth confirming this setting and doing a manual check during your

monthly review.

Settings›App Store›App Updates (toggle on)

To check for and install any pending updates manually, open the App Store, tap your profile icon in the top right, and scroll down to see any apps with updates available.

A final word

You have now worked through a complete, practical guide to protecting your iPhone, written specifically with everyday Australians in mind, not technology experts. That matters, because the vast majority of harm done by scammers and cybercriminals is not the result of sophisticated hacking. It is the result of ordinary people never being given a clear, simple explanation of what to watch for and what to do.

You no longer fall into that category. You understand what is actually on your phone and why it matters. You know the warning signs of a scam before it reaches you. You have a plan if your phone is ever lost. And you have a simple monthly routine to keep all of it current.

If this book has helped you, the most valuable thing you can do next is share what you have learned with someone else, a parent, a neighbour, a friend. Scammers succeed by targeting people in isolation. The more people around you who understand these basics, the safer your whole community becomes.

That is exactly the spirit this book was written in, and exactly the spirit behind Sfinco.

> **WELL DONE**
>
> You have completed Sfinco Guides Volume 1: iPhone Protection. Your iPhone is now meaningfully more secure than it was when you started this book. Well done. Genuinely.

Continuing your Sfinco journey: The Sfinco Guides series continues with Volume 2 (MacBook Protection), Volume 3 (Family and Home Network Protection), Volume 4 (Windows Protection), and Volume 5 (Android Protection), each written in the same plain-English, step-by-step style. See the final pages of this book for details.

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Glossary

These are the key terms used throughout this book, explained in plain English. You do not need to memorise them, this section is here to help if you encounter a word and want a clear definition.

Term	Definition
2FA / Two-Factor Authentication	A security method that requires two things to log in: your password, plus a code sent to your phone or device. Even if someone has your password, they cannot get in without the code.
Activation Lock	A feature that locks an iPhone to your Apple ID, making it impossible to erase or reactivate without your Apple ID password, even if the phone is factory reset.
Apple ID	The email address and password you use to sign in to Apple services, iCloud, the App Store, iMessage, FaceTime, and more. It is the master key to everything Apple.
App Privacy Report	An iOS feature that records which permissions your apps have accessed and which external servers they have contacted, giving you a log of actual app behaviour.
Encryption	The process of scrambling data so it can only be read by someone with the right key. HTTPS encrypts your web traffic; iCloud encrypts your backups.
Evil Twin	A fake Wi-Fi network set up to mimic a legitimate one. When your phone connects to it, the attacker can see your internet traffic.
Face ID	Apple's facial recognition system. It maps your face using 30,000+ infrared dots and uses that map to unlock your iPhone and authorise payments.
Find My	Apple's location and device tracking service. It lets you locate, lock, display a message on, or remotely erase your iPhone from another device.
HTTPS	The secure version of the web protocol. When a website address starts with https://, your connection

Term	Definition
	to it is encrypted, shown as a padlock in your browser.
iCloud	Apple's cloud storage service. It backs up your photos, contacts, messages, and settings, and allows them to be restored to a new device.
IDCARE	Australia's national identity and cyber support service. Free to use. Call 1800 595 160 if you have been affected by a scam or identity theft.
IMEI	A unique 15-digit number that identifies your specific iPhone. Needed when reporting theft to police. Found at Settings > General > About > IMEI.
Malware	Malicious software, programs designed to damage, spy on, or gain unauthorised access to a device. Rare on iPhone but possible through compromised apps.
Medical ID	An iOS feature that stores your medical conditions, allergies, and emergency contacts, visible from your lock screen without needing your passcode.
Passcode	The PIN or password used to unlock your iPhone. Can be four digits, six digits, or a custom alphanumeric code. Underpins all other iPhone security.
Permission	An explicit grant of access from you to an app, for example, allowing an app to use your camera, microphone, or location.
Phishing	A scam that impersonates a trusted organisation, via SMS, email, or a fake website, to trick you into handing over personal or financial information.
Scamwatch	The Australian government's national scam reporting service, run by the ACCC. Visit scamwatch.gov.au to

Term	Definition
	report scams or check current alerts.
SIM Swapping	An attack where a criminal convinces your mobile carrier to transfer your phone number to a SIM they control, giving them access to your SMS verification codes.
Stolen Device Protection	An iOS 17.3+ feature that requires Face ID (not just a passcode) to make sensitive account changes when your phone is away from trusted locations.
Tracking (App)	When an app follows your activity across other apps and websites to build an advertising profile. Requires your permission under iOS App Tracking Transparency.
VPN (Virtual Private Network)	A service that encrypts your internet traffic and routes it through a secure server. Particularly useful on public Wi-Fi to prevent interception.
Vishing	Voice phishing, a scam conducted by phone call rather than text or email, often impersonating banks, the ATO, or technology companies.
WPA2 / WPA3	Wi-Fi security protocols that encrypt wireless network traffic. WPA3 is the current standard; WPA2 is also acceptable. Older protocols (WEP, WPA) are insecure.

Quick reference card

Cut out or photograph this page and keep it somewhere handy, on the fridge, in your wallet, or saved as a photo on your phone. These are the numbers and steps you are most likely to need in a hurry.

Emergency contacts

Contact	Number / Website
My bank fraud line	_____
Scamwatch (ACCC)	scamwatch.gov.au · 1300 302 502
IDCARE (identity support)	idcare.org · 1800 595 160
ATO scam reporting	ato.gov.au · 1800 008 540
Apple Support	support.apple.com · 1800 APL TIP (1800 275 847)

My device details

Detail	Your entry
My iPhone model	_____
My iOS version	_____
My IMEI number	_____
My Apple ID email	_____
iCloud backup, last checked	_____

If your phone goes missing, first 30 minutes

Step	What to do
1. Locate it	icloud.com/find on any browser, or Find My app
2. Mark as Lost	In Find My, locks phone and displays your message
3. Call your bank	To flag Apple Pay on the device
4. Report to police	Provide IMEI and Find My location
5. Erase if needed	Find My > Erase This Device (last resort)

If you receive a suspicious message or call

Step	What to do
1. Do not click any links	And do not call numbers in the message
2. Find real contact details	Official website or card, not from the message
3. Verify independently	Call the organisation using their real number
4. Report it	scamwatch.gov.au and the impersonated organisation

Monthly security checkup

15 minutes · First Sunday of every month

Month / Year: _____ Completed by: _____

🚪 Front door

✓	Task	Reference
☐	Passcode is strong (Custom Alphanumeric or long numeric)	Ch 2
☐	Face ID working correctly	Ch 2
☐	Auto-Lock set to 30 seconds or 1 minute	Ch 2
☐	Stolen Device Protection ON	Ch 2

☁️ Apple ID & iCloud

✓	Task	Reference
☐	Two-factor authentication still active	Ch 3
☐	iCloud Backup successful within last 7 days	Ch 3
☐	No unrecognised devices on Apple ID	Ch 3

📱 Apps

✓	Task	Reference
☐	New apps reviewed for permissions	Ch 4
☐	App Privacy Report checked, nothing unusual	Ch 4
☐	Unused apps (3+ months) deleted	Ch 4

🚨 Scams

✓	Task	Reference
☐	Screen Unknown Senders still ON	Ch 5
☐	Screen Unknown Callers still ON	Ch 5

🛰️ Wi-Fi & VPN

✓	Task	Reference
☐	Auto-Join OFF for all public networks	Ch 6
☐	VPN app up to date	Ch 6

📍 Find My & emergency info

✓	Task	Reference
☐	Find My iPhone still ON	Ch 7
☐	Medical ID emergency contact still current	Ch 7

⚙️ Software

✓	Task	Reference
☐	iPhone running latest iOS version	Settings > General > Software Update
☐	All apps updated	App Store > Profile icon > Updates

More books in the series

The Sfinco Guides series is designed to cover every device and situation you are likely to encounter. Each book follows the same plain-English, step-by-step format, with real Australian examples, screenshots, and no technical jargon.

Series 1, Personal protection

Volume	What's inside
Vol 1 Available now	iPhone Protection Your simple guide to staying safe online Passcode · Face ID · Apple ID · App permissions · Scams · Wi-Fi · Find My
Vol 2 Coming soon	MacBook Protection Securing your Mac in plain English FileVault · Safari privacy · Gatekeeper · VPN · Time Machine backups · phishing
Vol 3 Coming soon	Family and Home Network Protection Keeping everyone safe under one roof Router security · parental controls · guest Wi-Fi · IoT devices · kids online
Vol 4 Coming soon	Windows Protection A plain-English guide for Windows users Windows Defender · BitLocker · updates · browser security · ransomware defence
Vol 5 Coming soon	Android Protection Staying safe on your Android phone Play Protect · app sideloading · Google account · 2FA · scam SMS

Series 2, Organisational protection

Volume	What's inside
Vol 6 Coming soon	Small Business Protection Cyber security for Australian small businesses Email security · staff access · backups · scam invoices · incident response
Vol 7 Coming soon	NGO and Not-for-Profit Protection Protecting organisations that protect others Volunteer access · donor data · email compromise · free tools for small teams
Vol 8 Coming soon	Personal Finance Protection Protecting your money in a digital world Banking security · investment scams · superannuation · password managers · wills

> **TIP**
> All Sfinco Guides are available on Amazon (search 'Sfinco Guides' or scan the QR code on the next page). Paperback and e-book editions are available. Bulk copies for community groups, RSL clubs, libraries, and medical practices are available directly through sfinco.com.au, contact us for pricing.

Scan to continue your Sfinco journey

Each QR code below links to a different part of the Sfinco ecosystem. Scan any of them with your iPhone camera to go directly to the relevant page.

Code	Where it goes
[QR CODE] WEBSITE	Visit the Sfinco website, free resources, guides, blog, and updates on new books in the series sfinco.com.au
[QR CODE] TECH HELP	Book a Senior Tech Concierge session, in-person help with your iPhone, iPad, or computer on the Sunshine Coast sfinco.com.au/concierge
[QR CODE] ALL BOOKS	Browse all Sfinco Guides, the complete series on Amazon and direct from our website sfinco.com.au/guides
[QR CODE] BUSINESS	Sfinco for business, cyber security audits and assessments for Sunshine Coast small businesses sfinco.com.au/business
[QR CODE] FREE DOWNLOAD	Free printable resources, scam reference card, monthly checklist, and more (no sign-up required) sfinco.com.au/resources

> **NOTE**
> QR codes are scanned using your iPhone camera app, no separate app needed. Simply open Camera, point it at the QR code, and tap the link that appears at the top of your screen. All Sfinco links are safe and will never ask for payment details.

About the author

Leon Tavares, author of the Sfinco Guides series, works in banking and technology on the Sunshine Coast in Queensland, with nearly two decades of experience across customer service, financial services, and digital security.

Holding qualifications in cybersecurity, financial advising, and information technology, and completing further studies in digital security, Leon brings together a rare combination of technical knowledge and the ability to explain it clearly to people who have no interest in becoming technical experts.

The inspiration for this series came from years of seeing the same pattern: intelligent, capable, careful people being harmed by scams and digital threats, not because they were careless, but because nobody had ever given them a clear, practical guide to protecting themselves. That gap is what these books exist to close.

Leon also volunteers with CoderDojo, teaching digital skills to young people on the Sunshine Coast, and has a background in community technology education across Australia and internationally.

Sfinco was founded on the belief that every Australian deserves to feel safe and confident in their digital life, regardless of their age, their technical background, or how much money they have.

Sfinco, Protecting Australians through technology, money, and trust.

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